

Why Public-Safety Wages May Grow Differently

A Visual Atlas of Municipal Compensation Evidence, Claims, and Limitations

A visual-first account of municipal compensation mechanisms, the evidence supporting fourteen final claim boundaries, the limits of the analysis, and the Human-AI workflow used to build the project.

35

reader-facing categories

14

final claims

7

retained counterexamples

0

causal estimates

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Executive summary

The corpus supports a bounded account of compensation mechanisms more strongly than a national wage-gap or causal estimate.

What the project investigated

Why public-safety wages may grow differently from other municipal occupations, using documentary and administrative evidence while holding city and compensation cycle central to comparison.

What the evidence supports

One supported bounded account, one conditional claim, five mechanism-only claims, and one mixed finding. Safety-side events are more visible in retained classified evidence, but that visibility is not national prevalence.

What it does not establish

No national safety wage gap, representative growth advantage, prevalence estimate, regression result, or causal effect. Six proposed global claims remain unsupported.

1,029,482

unique native PDF pages

14,160

usable external payloads

2,998

implementation events

13,391

mechanism-event link records

How to use this atlas: begin with the reader guide, then read the corpus pages before interpreting the mechanism maps. Each profile states what a compensation mechanism means, how it can affect pay, which side is more visible, and what the evidence cannot prove. The final sections preserve counterexamples, limitations, and project history.

Research question and analytical units

The project compares occupations within municipalities while keeping city and compensation cycle central.

Research question

Why might public-safety compensation grow differently from pay in other municipal occupations? The strongest design compares separate bargaining units in the same city and overlapping compensation cycle.

One implementation event

A deduplicated municipality × compensation cycle × compensation mechanism × side record. It documents an administrative or contractual compensation event; it is not a worker, source document, wage effect, or prevalence estimate.

Safety

Police, fire, or combined public-safety evidence.

Non-safety

Municipal occupations outside police and fire.

Mixed

A record that concerns both safety and non-safety sides.

Side-independent

A municipal process or record without an occupation-specific side.

Unresolved

The available evidence does not support a precise side assignment.

Different units

Sources, pages, spans, events, municipalities, claims, and comparisons are reported separately and cannot be added.

Maps and evidence tiers

Map shading describes documented events; evidence tiers describe how safely a record can support a claim.

How to read a hex map

A hex map groups nearby municipalities into equal-sized areas so regional patterns are easier to see. Darker areas contain more distinct documented compensation events. The shading does not represent more employees, a larger wage effect, or how common the mechanism is nationwide. Alaska uses a separate inset scale.

Broader evidence can strengthen a bounded interpretation without changing its claim class. In this project, five claims became stronger within the same class, one became more mixed, eight were unchanged, and none upgraded class.

Strict evidence

Exact and claim-safe: compatible subject, municipality, period, side, role, pay basis, and traceable formula.

Bounded evidence

Analytically usable with an explicit caveat about role, period, range, or another limited dimension.

Directional evidence

Supports a mechanism or direction but not a clean point estimate.

Context

Relevant background that does not directly support a claim.

Rejected

Incompatible, duplicate, conflicted, or unsupported evidence kept outside claim support.

Core compensation-mechanism glossary

Plain-language definitions used throughout the mechanism profiles.

● Compensation mechanism

A process or rule that sets, changes, delays, funds, or supplements pay.

● Compensation cycle

The fiscal, contract, bargaining, or implementation period to which an event belongs.

● Documentary evidence

Contracts, ordinances, agreements, awards, reports, and related documents.

● Administrative record

Payroll, staffing, budget, personnel, or implementation material.

● Retroactive pay

Back pay owed because a term applies to an earlier effective period.

● Step progression

Movement through a salary schedule based on service, rank, or another rule.

● COLA

A cost-of-living adjustment, sometimes linked to inflation or a price index.

● Across-the-board raise

The same general increase applied across covered roles or classifications.

● Non-base pay

Overtime, premiums, stipends, allowances, longevity, or other pay outside the base rate.

● Bargaining leverage

Practical power used to improve terms during negotiations.

● Staffing pressure

Vacancy, recruitment, retention, or minimum-staffing conditions entering pay decisions.

● Pay plan

A formal municipal schedule or process that establishes compensation rates.

● Salary schedule

A table of rates, grades, steps, or ranges for covered jobs.

● Classification adjustment

A change to a job's grade, band, range, or civil-service placement.

● Compression

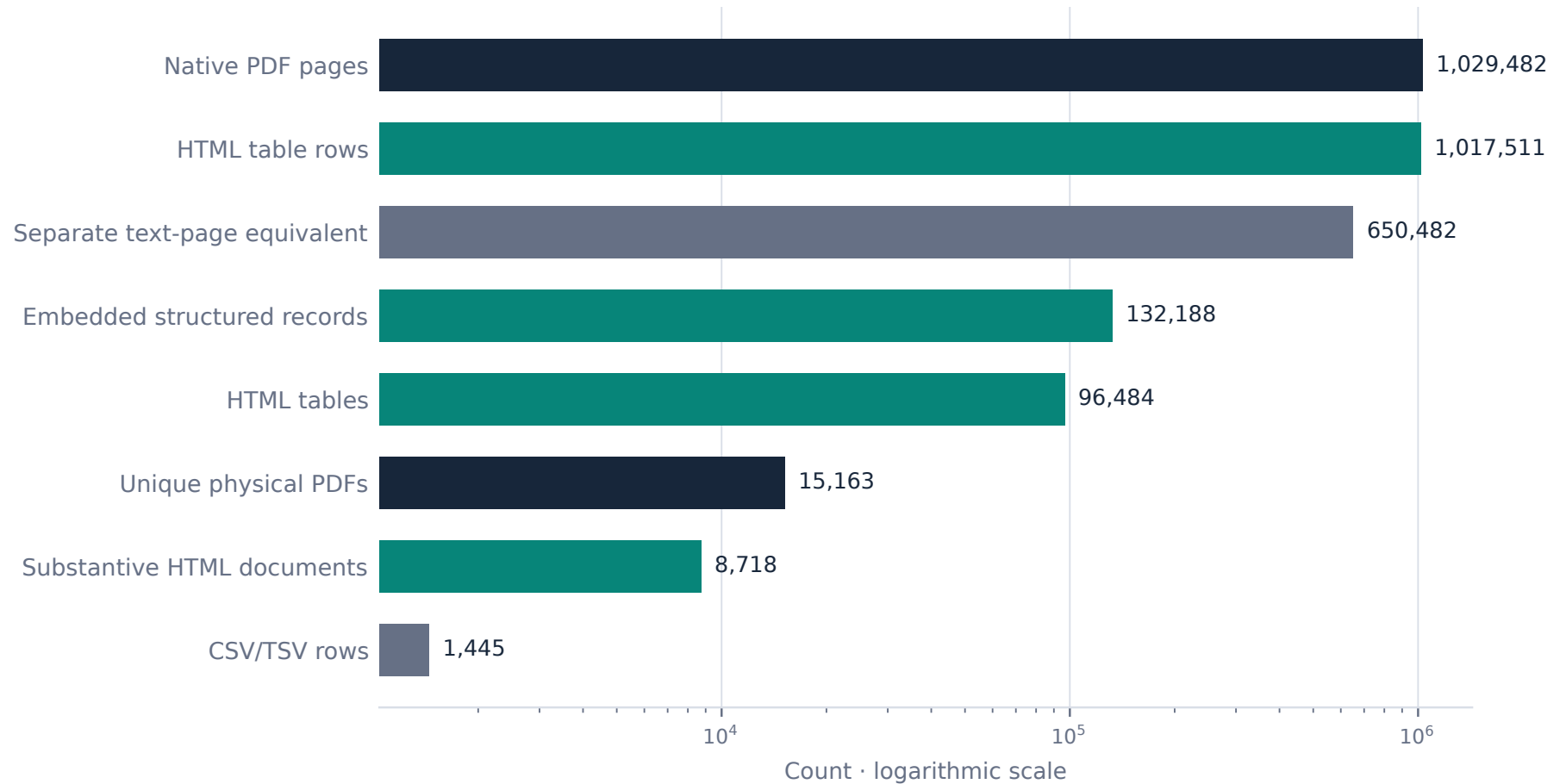
A narrowing pay difference between experience levels, ranks, or related roles.

● Premium pay

Additional pay for specific duties, qualifications, shifts, or working conditions.

Corpus scale and source mix

The project assembled a large, mixed-format corpus, but different source units are never combined into one total.

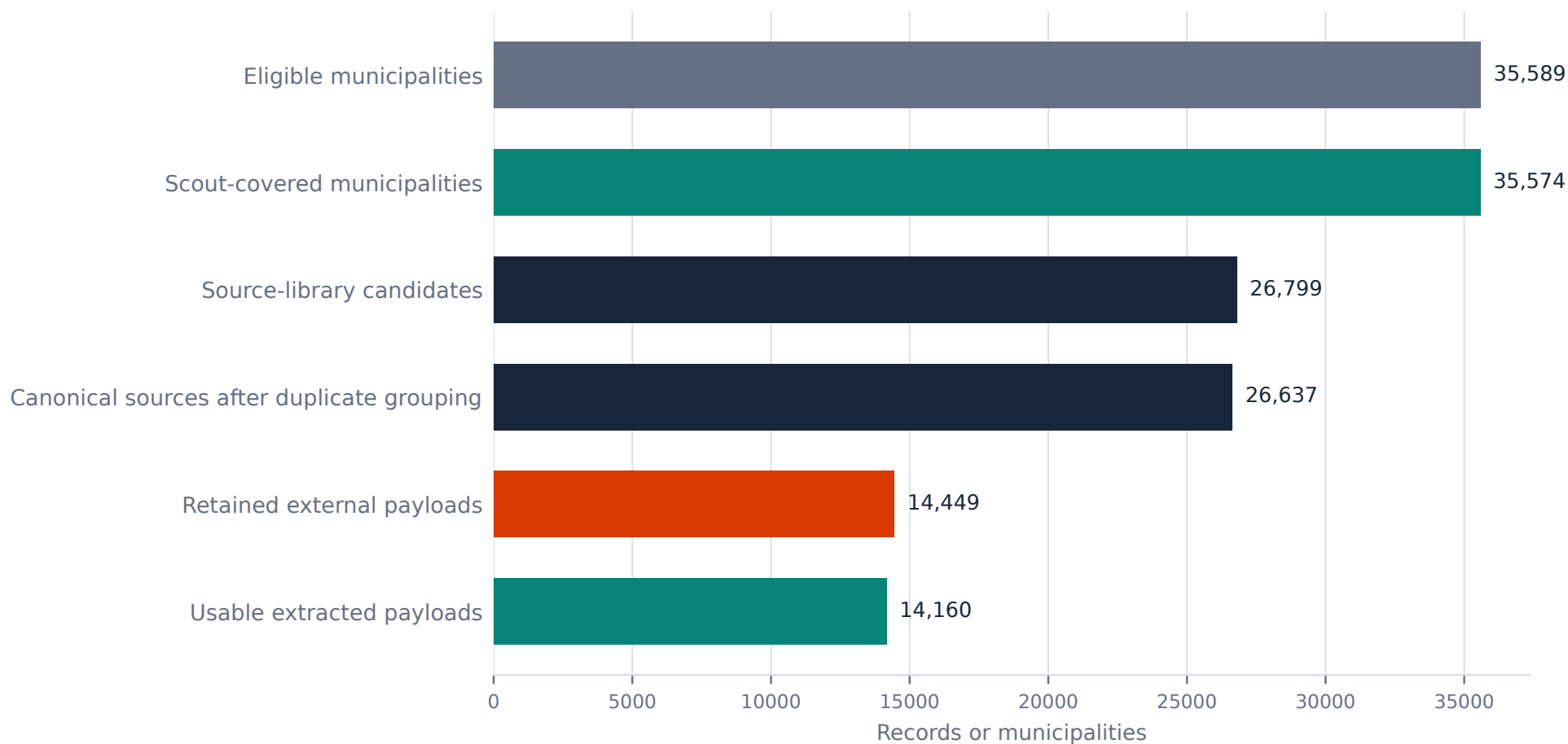


Exact values are labeled. Counts have different analytical units and are not additive.

Native PDF pages and the separate non-PDF text-page equivalent are never added together.

Discovery, retention, and usable evidence

Near-complete municipality scouting did not make every discovered source accessible, retained, or analytically compatible.

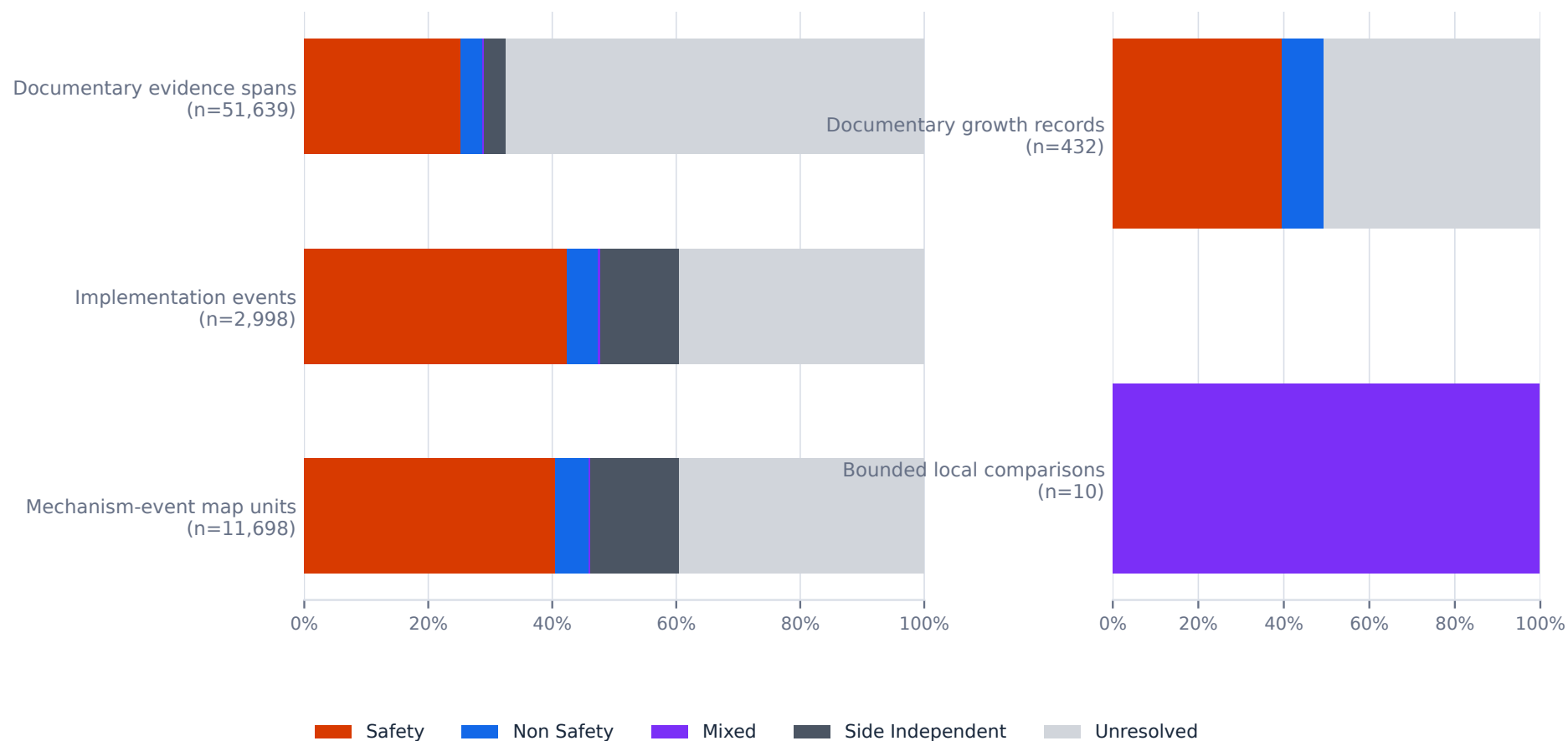


Filtering, duplicate grouping, storage holds, and readiness checks are expected pipeline decisions, not accidental loss.

Scout coverage is a discovery result, not representative sampling or national prevalence.

Safety and non-safety visibility

Safety appears more often in retained classified evidence; unresolved and side-independent material remains visible.

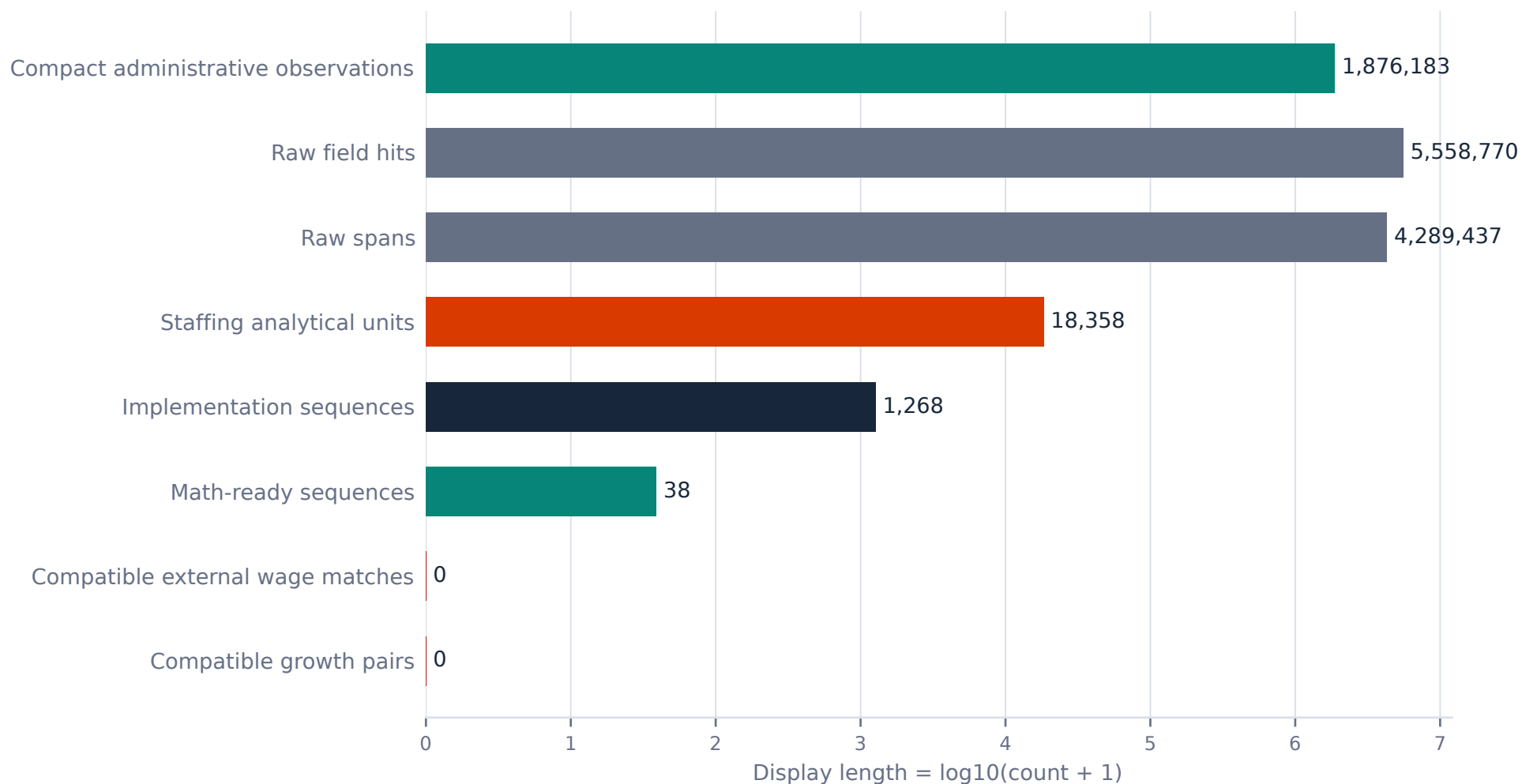


Rows use different analytical units and cannot be added. Local comparisons are intrinsically two-sided and are shown as mixed.

Each row has its own analytical unit and denominator. The rows cannot be added.

Analytical readiness and evidence boundaries

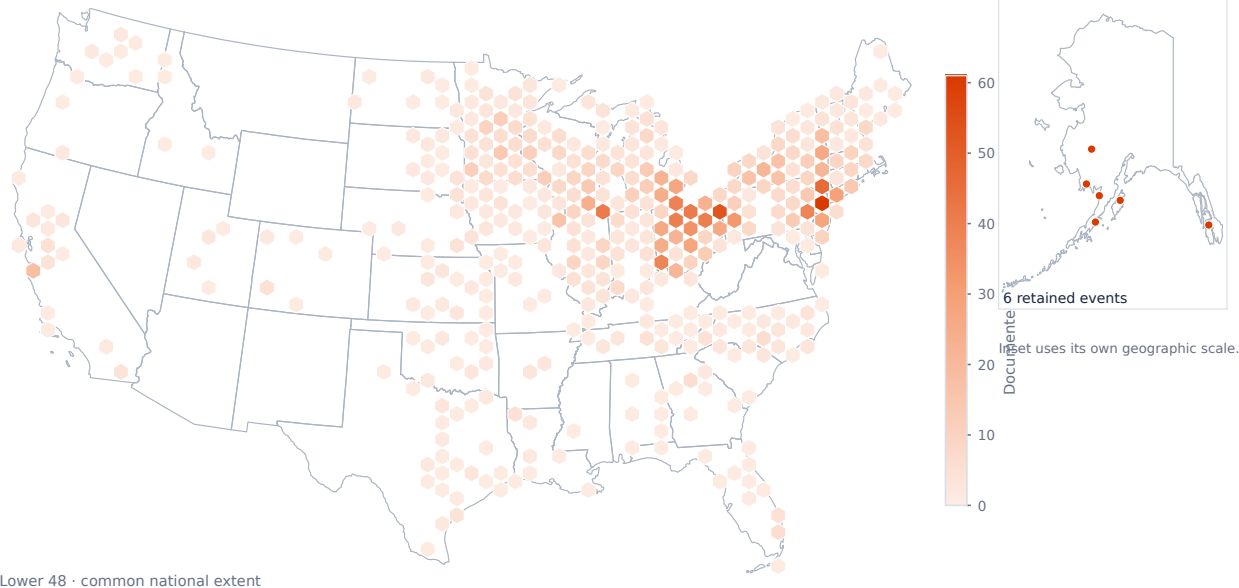
Millions of extracted records became compact evidence layers, but strict compatibility gates still produced no external wage or growth panel.



Zero compatible external wage matches and growth pairs reflect unit incompatibility, not a lack of documents.

Retroactivity and payroll timing

2,253 distinct profile events · 1,269 municipalities · 42 states



What the mechanism means

A compensation term whose effective date reaches back before the final approval or payment date.

How it can affect pay

It can push compensation upward by making a later settlement effective for earlier work. It converts the earlier effective period into an owed payment, often delivered as back pay. It determines when an approved increase starts reaching paychecks and prevents adoption dates from being mistaken for

Side pattern

Safety 945 · Non-safety 114 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 1,194.

Example in the retained evidence

Flint charter, MI: a cba record codes retroactivity implementation for police_direct; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

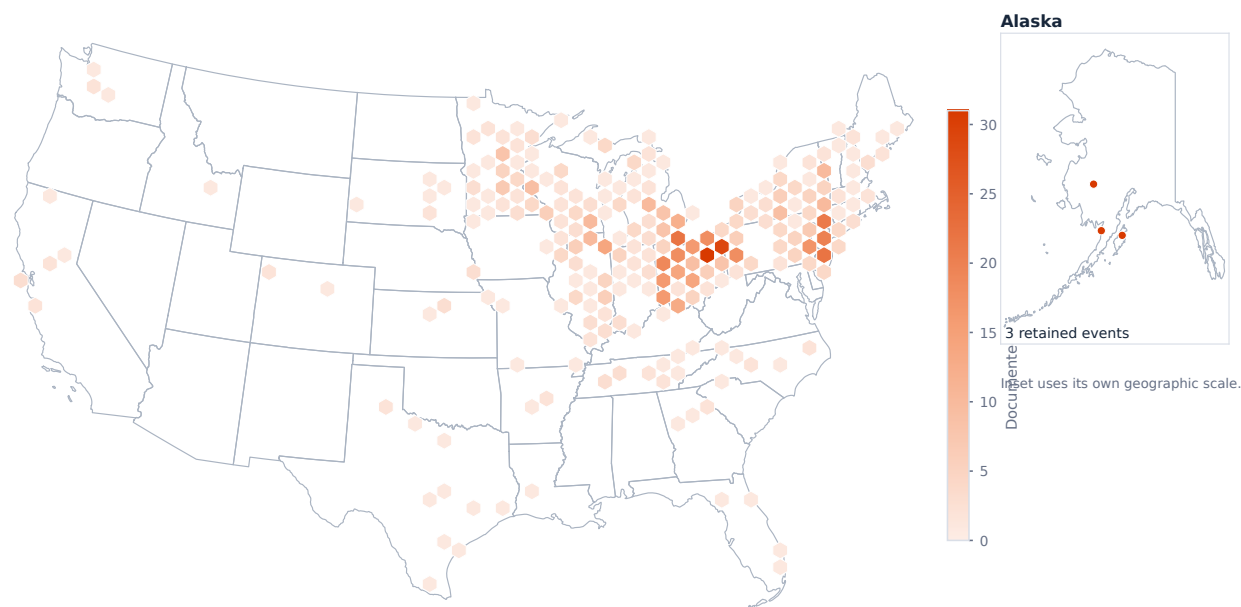
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

A compensation term whose effective date reaches back before the final approval or payment date. It can push compensation upward by making a later settlement effective for earlier work. It converts the earlier effective period into an owed payment, often delivered as back pay. It determines when an approved increase starts reaching paychecks and prevents adoption dates from being mistaken for payment. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (945 versus 114) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more common in the corpus. It does not establish national prevalence or a wage effect.

Non-base and one-time compensation

890 distinct profile events · 551 municipalities · 32 states



What the mechanism means

Compensation outside regular base wages that does not fit a more specific category.

How it can affect pay

It adds pay outside the base rate, so a base-wage comparison can miss part of compensation. It raises pay for specific duties, qualifications, shifts, or working conditions. It increases cash compensation or reimburses required job costs without changing base pay. It can substantially increase earnings beyond base

Side pattern

Safety 452 · Non-safety 37 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 401.

Example in the retained evidence

Milaca, MN: a cba record codes non base compensation for police_direct; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

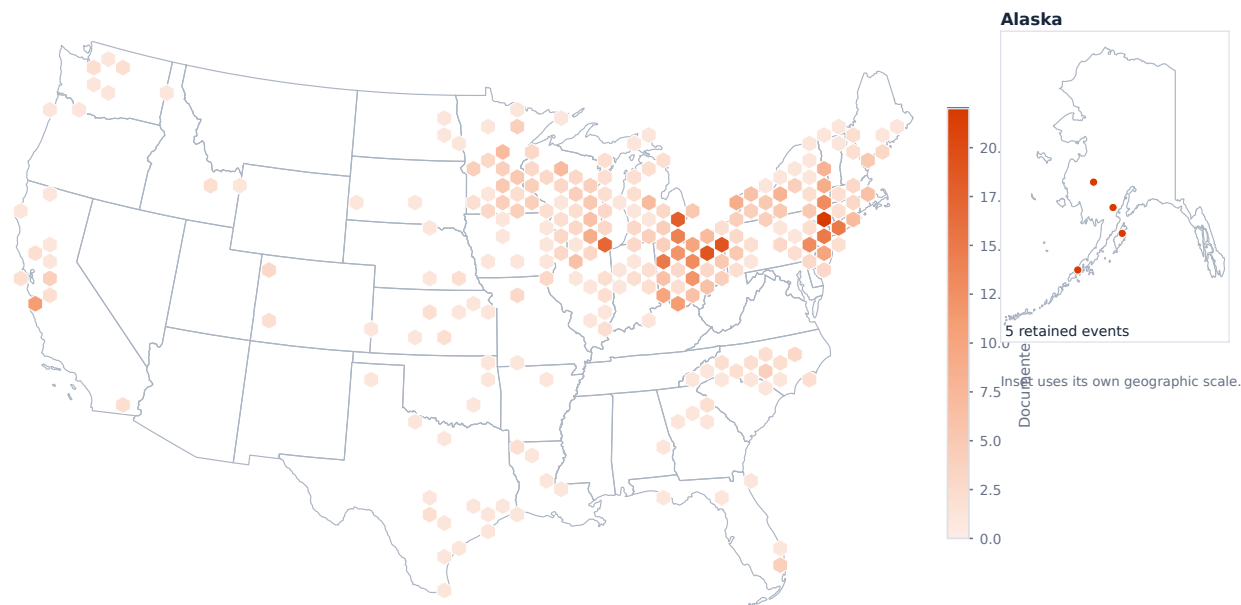
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

Compensation outside regular base wages that does not fit a more specific category. It adds pay outside the base rate, so a base-wage comparison can miss part of compensation. It raises pay for specific duties, qualifications, shifts, or working conditions. It increases cash compensation or reimburses required job costs without changing base pay. It can substantially increase earnings beyond base pay when staffing or scheduling produces extra hours. It adds premium compensation for holiday work or recognized holidays. It adds scheduled pay as service accumulates and can steepen wage growth for long-tenured workers. It can change total compensation or take-home value even when base wages do not move. It offsets work expenses but should not be treated as recurring wages. It raises current

Scheduled base-wage growth

809 distinct profile events · 540 municipalities · 36 states



What the mechanism means

The same general increase applied across covered jobs or classifications.

How it can affect pay

It raises covered rates together, but does not necessarily change the gap between safety and non-safety jobs. It directly changes recurring salary or wage rates. It can generate repeated wage growth as employees move through scheduled steps. It can preserve purchasing power by linking raises to

Side pattern

Safety 384 · Non-safety 32 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 393.

Example in the retained evidence

Wellsville, NY: a cba record codes step schedule seniority for police_direct; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

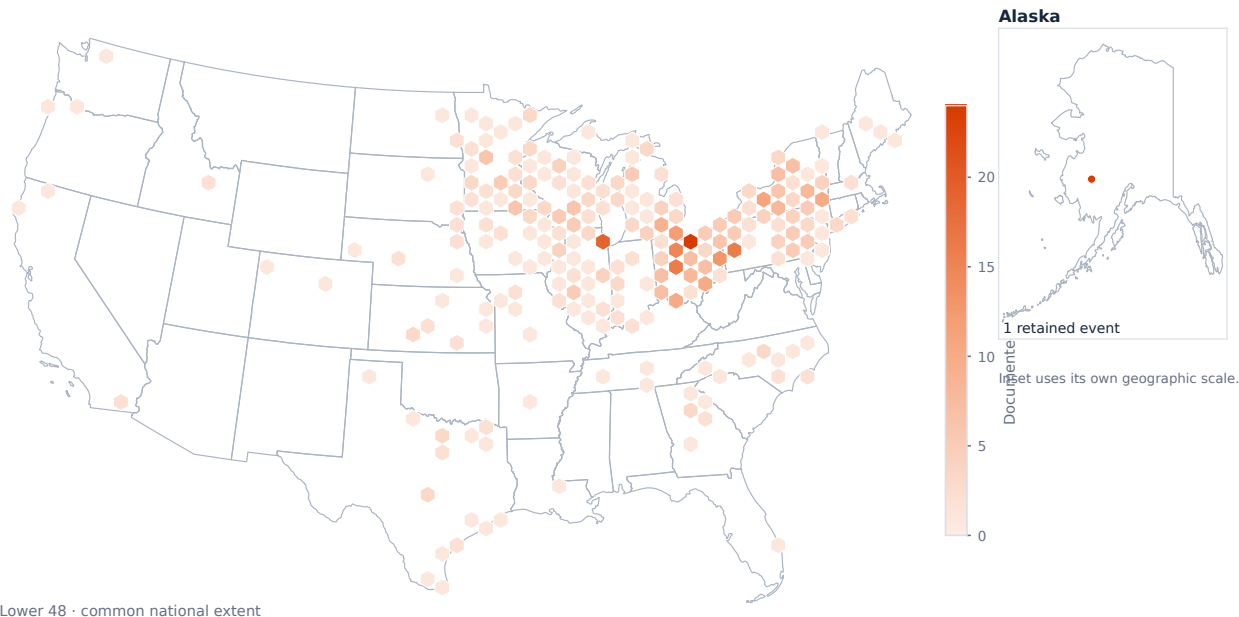
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

The same general increase applied across covered jobs or classifications. It raises covered rates together, but does not necessarily change the gap between safety and non-safety jobs. It directly changes recurring salary or wage rates. It can generate repeated wage growth as employees move through scheduled steps. It can preserve purchasing power by linking raises to inflation or a stated percentage. It can trigger recurring adjustments as inflation changes. It raises future compensation repeatedly because the amount remains in the pay structure. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (384 versus 32) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more

Budgets, pay plans, and fiscal constraint

636 distinct profile events · 409 municipalities · 33 states



What the mechanism means

A budget or pay-plan process that formally sets or revises compensation schedules.

How it can affect pay

It can authorize, sequence, or constrain the schedules through which wages become operative. It can hold pay down, delay implementation, or redirect increases toward narrower groups or one-time payments. It supplies the legal or financial authority for compensation to be paid.

Side pattern

Safety 154 · Non-safety 69 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 413.

Example in the retained evidence

Huntington Bay, NY: a `arbitration_award` record codes budget fiscal constraint for `police_direct`; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

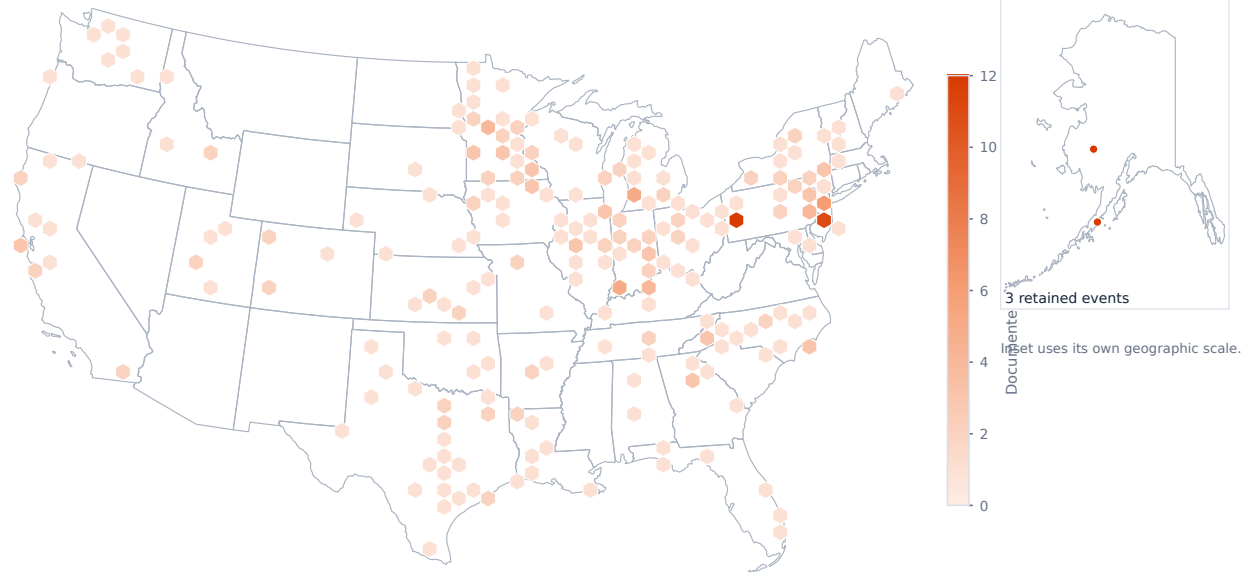
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

A budget or pay-plan process that formally sets or revises compensation schedules. It can authorize, sequence, or constrain the schedules through which wages become operative. It can hold pay down, delay implementation, or redirect increases toward narrower groups or one-time payments. It supplies the legal or financial authority for compensation to be paid. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (154 versus 69) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more common in the corpus. It does not establish national prevalence or a wage effect.

Council and ordinance adoption

315 distinct profile events · 271 municipalities · 38 states



What the mechanism means

A city council or ordinance action that formally authorizes compensation terms.

How it can affect pay

It turns a proposal or agreement into an authorized municipal action, although authorization is not proof of payment. It formalizes compensation terms, but the retained evidence must still show implementation or payment separately.

Side pattern

Safety 76 · Non-safety 21 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 218.

Example in the retained evidence

Washington, PA: a agenda_packet_or_minutes record codes ordinance council adoption for police_direct; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

A city council or ordinance action that formally authorizes compensation terms. It turns a proposal or agreement into an authorized municipal action, although authorization is not proof of payment. It formalizes compensation terms, but the retained evidence must still show implementation or payment separately. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (76 versus 21) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more common in the corpus. It does not establish national prevalence or a wage effect.

Formal bargaining and impasse resolution

81 distinct profile events · 69 municipalities · 22 states



What the mechanism means

The practical power employees or unions can use to win better terms during negotiations.

How it can affect pay

It can improve negotiated terms when employees can credibly apply staffing, political, legal, or job-action pressure. It provides the formal channel through which wage schedules and non-base terms are negotiated. It can implement targeted changes faster or more narrowly than a complete successor contract. It

Side pattern

Safety 42 · Non-safety 5 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 34.

Example in the retained evidence

Harrison, OH: a mou_or_memo record codes collective bargaining for police_direct; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

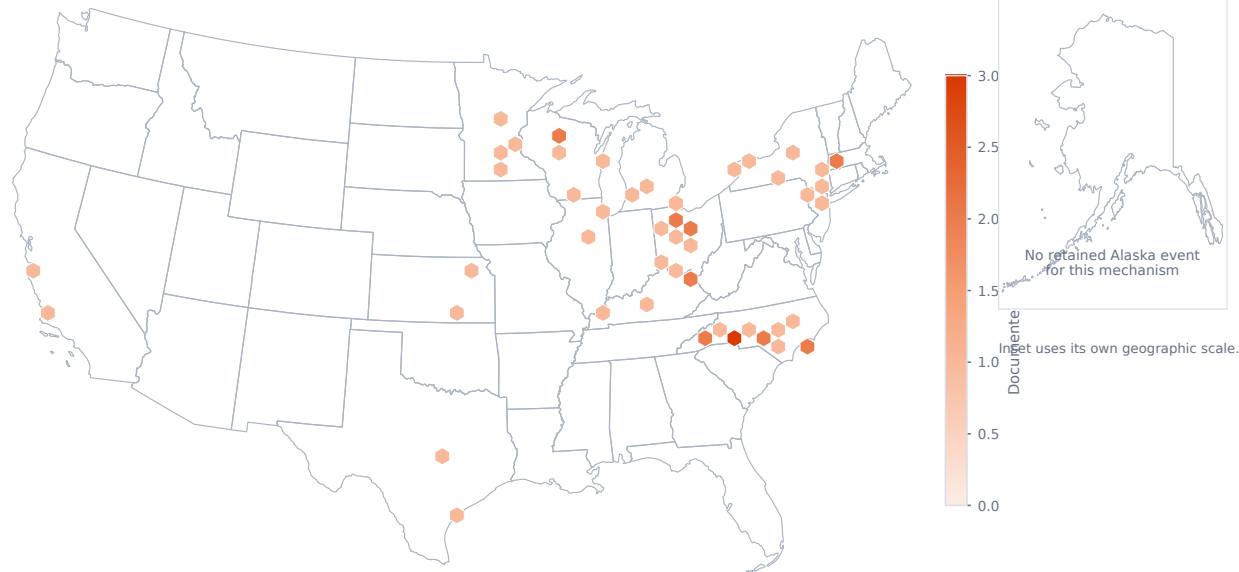
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

The practical power employees or unions can use to win better terms during negotiations. It can improve negotiated terms when employees can credibly apply staffing, political, legal, or job-action pressure. It provides the formal channel through which wage schedules and non-base terms are negotiated. It can implement targeted changes faster or more narrowly than a complete successor contract. It approves negotiated terms but remains distinct from their payroll-effective or paid stage. It can impose compensation terms when ordinary bargaining reaches an impasse. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (42 versus 5) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to

Classification and pay structure

57 distinct profile events · 54 municipalities · 14 states



Lower 48 · common national extent

What the mechanism means

A change to a job classification, pay grade, range, or band.

How it can affect pay

It can raise or lower attainable pay by moving a job into a different grade or range. It changes the floor, ceiling, or spread of possible pay rather than necessarily changing observed earnings immediately. It governs placement and progression in ways that can structure long-run pay paths.

Side pattern

Safety 23 · Non-safety 2 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 32.

Example in the retained evidence

Franklin, IN: a `budget_or_pay_plan` record codes classification civil service for `police_direct`; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

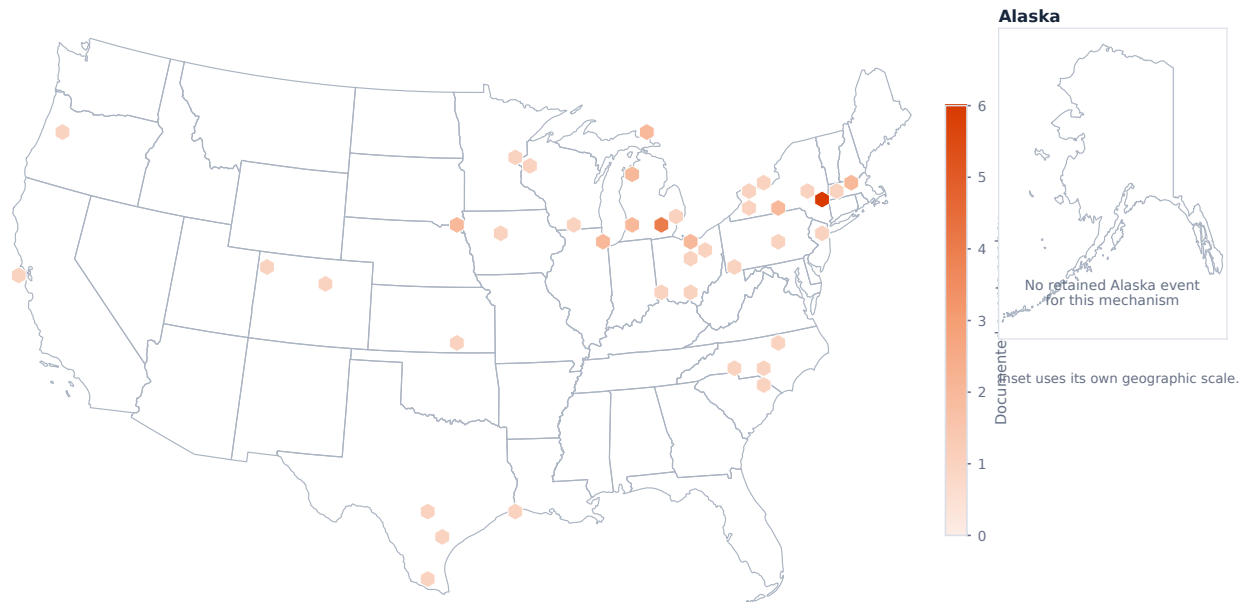
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

A change to a job classification, pay grade, range, or band. It can raise or lower attainable pay by moving a job into a different grade or range. It changes the floor, ceiling, or spread of possible pay rather than necessarily changing observed earnings immediately. It governs placement and progression in ways that can structure long-run pay paths. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (23 versus 2) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more common in the corpus. It does not establish national prevalence or a wage effect.

Staffing, market, and comparability pressure

56 distinct profile events · 47 municipalities · 17 states



What the mechanism means

A pay action justified by labor-market competition, hiring, or retention pressure.

How it can affect pay

It can produce targeted raises or premiums when employers struggle to hire or keep workers. It can motivate targeted raises, premiums, or retention measures when positions are hard to fill. It can pull pay toward a reference job, bargaining unit, or neighboring jurisdiction.

Side pattern

Safety 22 · Non-safety 7 · Mixed, side-independent, or unresolved 27.

Example in the retained evidence

Ontario, NY: a `civil_service_or_hr_pay_plan` record codes market recruitment retention for `non_safety_direct`; the package preserves the bounded evidence pointer and source lineage.

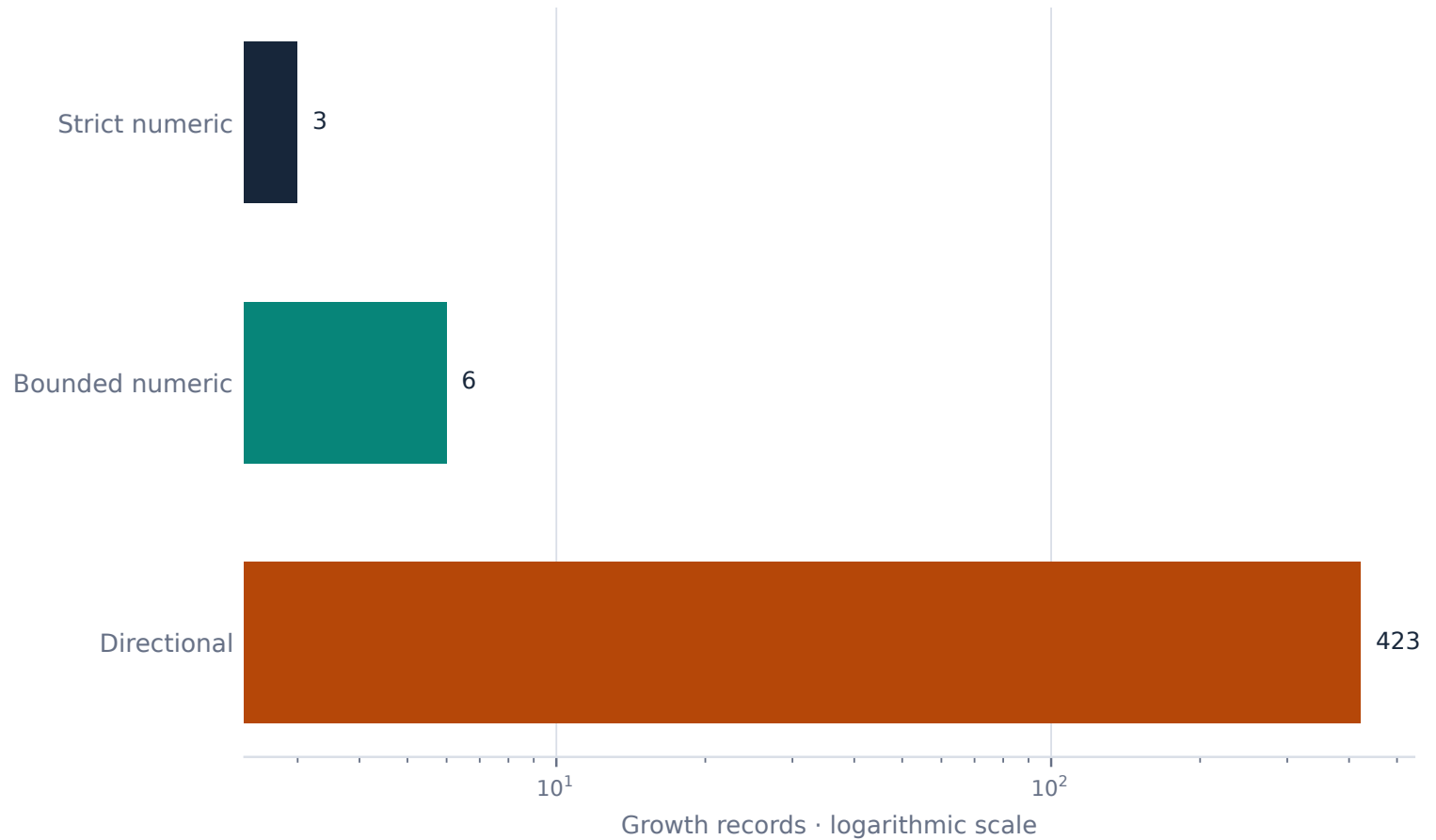
Claim boundary

local/mechanism/sample-specific; no national wage gap, prevalence, or causal effect

A pay action justified by labor-market competition, hiring, or retention pressure. It can produce targeted raises or premiums when employers struggle to hire or keep workers. It can motivate targeted raises, premiums, or retention measures when positions are hard to fill. It can pull pay toward a reference job, bargaining unit, or neighboring jurisdiction. Among side-classified events, safety appears more often (22 versus 7) in the retained evidence. That pattern matters because it shows which side is more visible in the documents I could classify, but safety records were also easier to identify and more common in the corpus. It does not establish national prevalence or a wage effect.

Documentary growth by evidence tier

Step progression leans safety, across-the-board results are mixed, and COLA evidence is sparse.



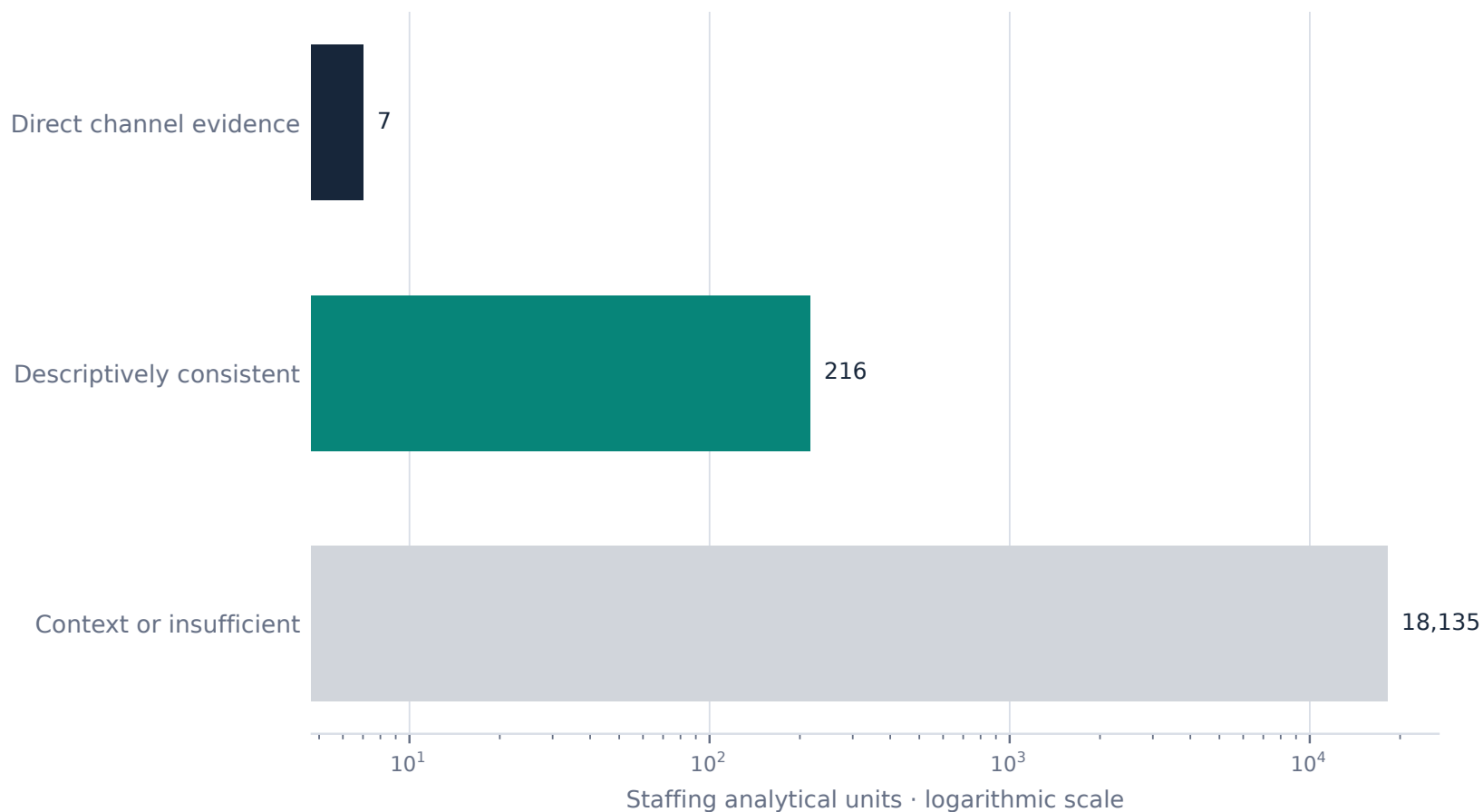
432 total records. Step progression leans safety; across-board results are mixed; COLA evidence is sparse.

Interpretation boundary

Growth results remain mechanism-specific and sample-specific; they do not establish a uniform national safety advantage.

Staffing pressure and channel evidence

A small direct channel sits inside a much larger descriptive and unresolved staffing layer.



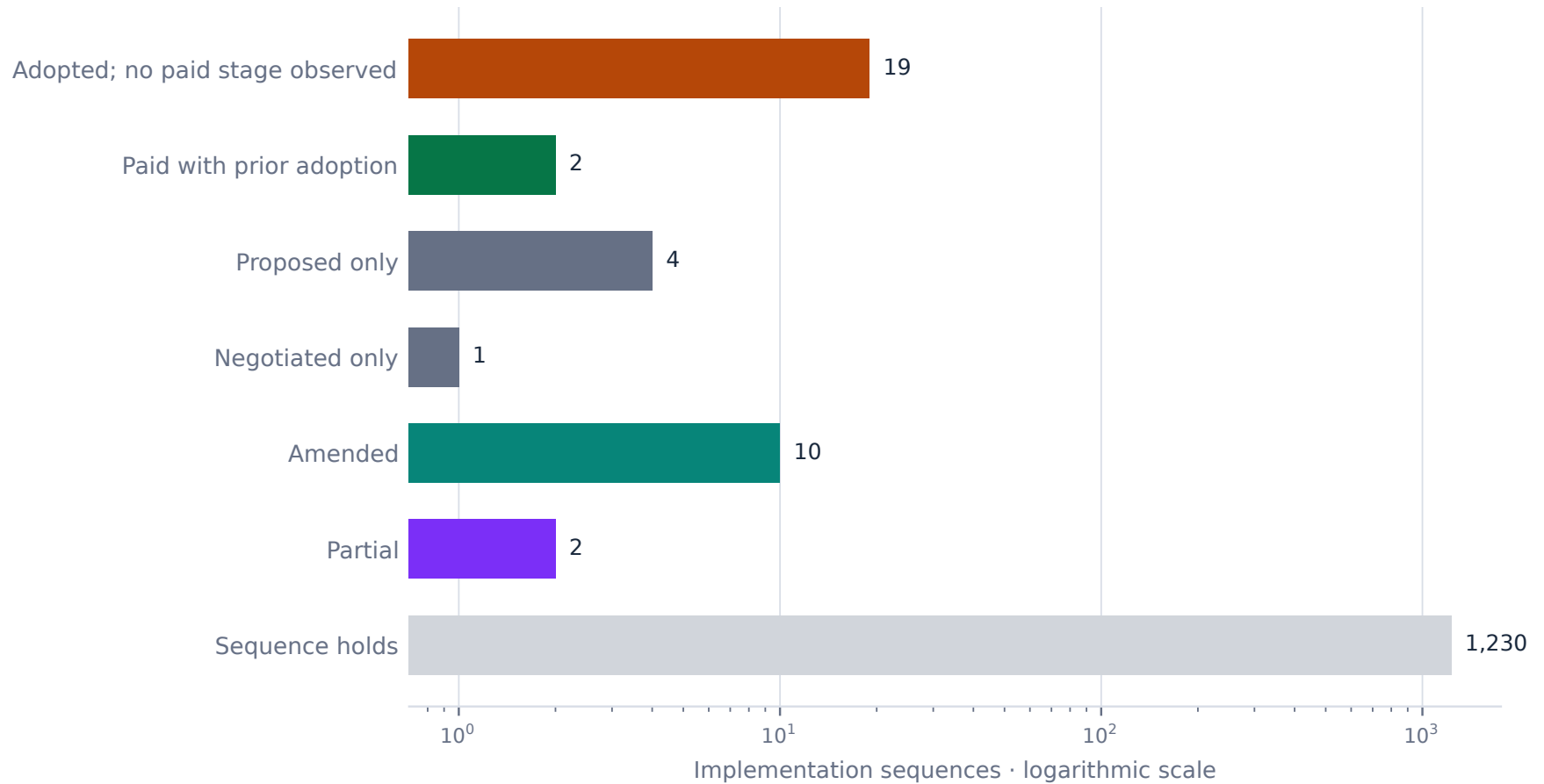
18,358 units total. These are descriptive and mechanism-oriented; no causal effect was estimated.

Interpretation boundary

Staffing evidence is descriptive and mechanism-oriented. No causal effect was estimated.

Implementation lifecycle

Adoption, effective date, payroll operation, and payment are distinct stages.



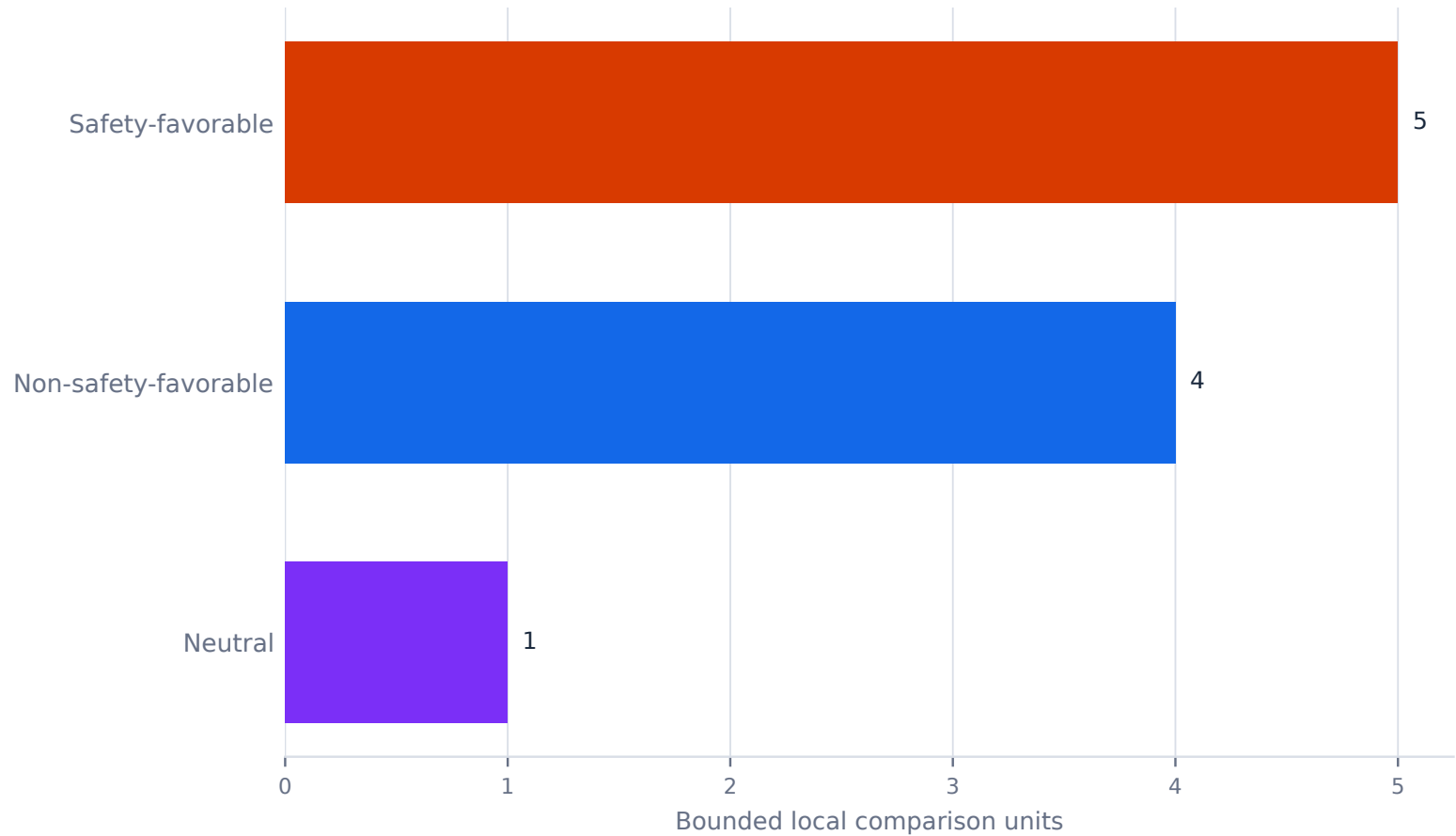
Adoption, effective date, likely implementation, payroll-effective status, and paid status remain distinct.

Interpretation boundary

Use “no paid stage observed in the retained evidence,” never “never paid.”

Ten bounded local comparisons

Five favor safety, four favor non-safety, and one is neutral.



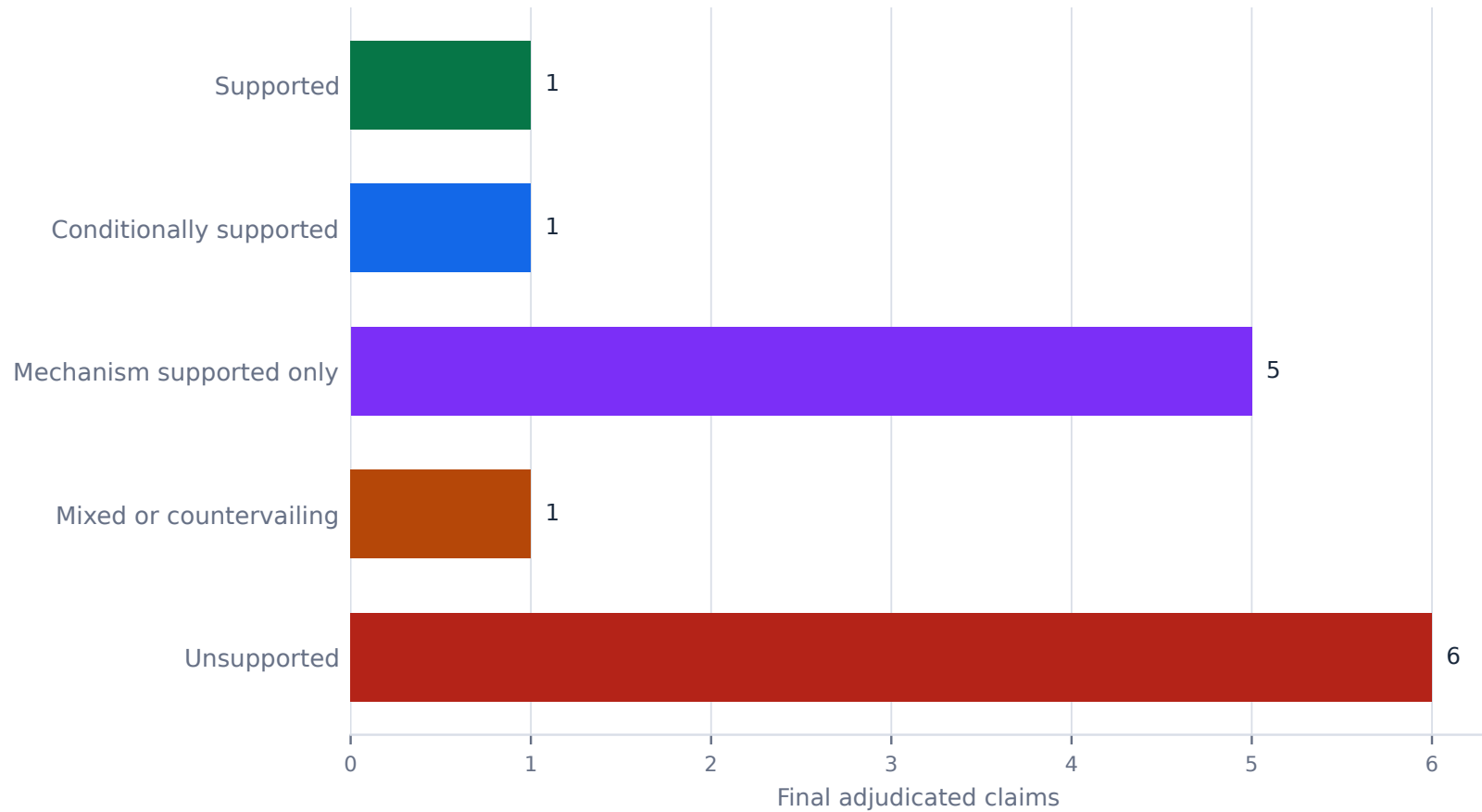
Ten local comparisons: nine bounded numeric and one directional. They are local examples, not a national estimate.

Interpretation boundary

Local comparisons remain local and are not averaged into a national wage-gap estimate.

Final claim classes

The final universe contains fourteen claims; evidence volume alone does not determine support.



All 14 classes are preserved. Evidence volume alone does not determine class.

One claim is supported, one is conditionally supported, five are mechanism supported only, one is mixed or countervailing, and six remain unsupported. No claim is exploratory or contradicted.

Evidence matrix: bounded findings

Eight claims supported, qualified, or bounded by mechanism and countervailing evidence.

	Strict	Bounded	Directional	Counterexamples	Conflicts
Formal bargaining and impasse resolution	6	0	1	0	0
Scheduled wage-growth mechanisms	7	6	423	0	0
Non-base compensation channels	2	0	1	0	0
Staffing and labor-market pressure	4	7	217	0	0
Retroactivity and implementation timing	40	0	1	0	0
Fiscal institutions and formal adoption	44	0	1	0	0
Mixed and countervailing evidence	11	15	424	7	0
A bounded compensation-mechanism account	52	23	677	7	0

Cells are linked-record counts; color intensity uses $\log(1 + \text{count})$. Large directional counts are not equivalent to strict evidence.

Cells show linked-record counts. Color intensity uses $\log(1 + \text{count})$ to keep large directional layers readable. Counts are not equally weighted proof, and a zero count does not by itself disprove a claim.

Evidence matrix: unsupported boundaries

Six proposed global claims remain unsupported because the required analytical design is absent.

	Strict	Bounded	Directional	Counterexamples	Conflicts
No national safety wage-gap estimate	0	0	0	0	0
No national mechanism-prevalence estimate	0	0	0	0	0
No causal-effect estimate	0	0	0	0	0
No regression-based claim	0	0	0	0	0
No uniform safety growth advantage	0	0	0	0	0
Documentation is not causal identification	0	0	0	0	0

Cells are linked-record counts; color intensity uses $\log(1 + \text{count})$. Large directional counts are not equivalent to strict evidence.

Cells show linked-record counts. Color intensity uses $\log(1 + \text{count})$ to keep large directional layers readable. Counts are not equally weighted proof, and a zero count does not by itself disprove a claim.

Claims CLAIM-A and CLAIM-B

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

Formal bargaining and impasse resolution

Mechanism supported only

What I can responsibly say

In the reviewed corpus, formal bargaining, arbitration, and factfinding provide recurring institutional channels that can set or preserve safety-compensation terms; the evidence establishes mechanism operation, not an average wage effect.

Strict conclusion

In the reviewed corpus, formal bargaining, arbitration, and factfinding provide recurring institutional channels that can set or preserve safety-compensation terms.

Broader bounded conclusion

In the reviewed corpus, formal bargaining, arbitration, and factfinding provide recurring institutional channels that can set or preserve safety-compensation terms; the evidence establishes mechanism operation, not an average wage effect.

What I cannot responsibly say

Formal bargaining causes safety wages to rise faster nationwide.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Scheduled wage-growth mechanisms

Conditionally supported

What I can responsibly say

In reviewed unit-cycle records, step, seniority, rank, and COLA provisions create recurring scheduled wage-growth paths; step progression leans safety in the available sample, while across-board results are mixed and COLA cells are sparse.

Strict conclusion

The reviewed documentary corpus contains recurring step, seniority, rank, and COLA structures; comparative growth implications remain sample-specific.

Broader bounded conclusion

In reviewed unit-cycle records, step, seniority, rank, and COLA provisions create recurring scheduled wage-growth paths; step progression leans safety in the available sample, while across-board results are mixed and COLA cells are sparse.

What I cannot responsibly say

Safety wages generally grow faster nationwide because of step progression or COLAs.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims CLAIM-C and CLAIM-D

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

Non-base compensation channels

Mechanism supported only

What I can responsibly say

Reviewed safety-compensation records contain structured non-base channels—including overtime, holiday, longevity, premium, stipend, and allowance provisions—that can raise compensation beyond base pay; no complete total-compensation sum is estimated.

Strict conclusion

Reviewed safety-compensation records contain structured non-base channels—including overtime, holiday, longevity, premium, stipend, and allowance provisions—that can raise compensation beyond base pay.

Broader bounded conclusion

Reviewed safety-compensation records contain structured non-base channels—including overtime, holiday, longevity, premium, stipend, and allowance provisions—that can raise compensation beyond base pay; no complete total-compensation sum is estimated.

What I cannot responsibly say

Safety workers receive more total compensation than non-safety workers nationwide.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Staffing and labor-market pressure

Mechanism supported only

What I can responsibly say

Reviewed sources explicitly use recruitment, retention, comparator, vacancy, and staffing pressure to justify schedule changes or targeted premiums in some public-safety settings; the staffing evidence is descriptive, not causal or prevalence evidence.

Strict conclusion

Reviewed sources explicitly use recruitment, retention, comparator, vacancy, and staffing pressure to justify schedule changes or targeted premiums in some public-safety settings.

Broader bounded conclusion

Reviewed sources explicitly use recruitment, retention, comparator, vacancy, and staffing pressure to justify schedule changes or targeted premiums in some public-safety settings; the staffing evidence is descriptive, not causal or prevalence evidence.

What I cannot responsibly say

Staffing shortages cause higher safety wages.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims CLAIM-E and CLAIM-F

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

Retroactivity and implementation timing

Mechanism supported only

What I can responsibly say

Reviewed records show that retroactive effective dates and implementation clauses can convert some bargaining delays into payable increases or back pay; adoption alone is not payment, and only retained evidence with a paid stage is described as paid.

Strict conclusion

Reviewed records show that retroactive effective dates and implementation clauses can convert some bargaining delays into payable increases or back pay.

Broader bounded conclusion

Reviewed records show that retroactive effective dates and implementation clauses can convert some bargaining delays into payable increases or back pay; adoption alone is not payment, and only retained evidence with a paid stage is described as paid.

What I cannot responsibly say

Every adopted or retroactive provision was implemented and paid.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Fiscal institutions and formal adoption

Mechanism supported only

What I can responsibly say

Reviewed ordinances, budgets, pay plans, and classification records show how compensation proposals can be formalized or constrained by fiscal institutions; these records do not establish that every proposal was implemented or paid.

Strict conclusion

Reviewed ordinances, budgets, pay plans, and classification records show how compensation proposals can be formalized or constrained by fiscal institutions.

Broader bounded conclusion

Reviewed ordinances, budgets, pay plans, and classification records show how compensation proposals can be formalized or constrained by fiscal institutions; these records do not establish that every proposal was implemented or paid.

What I cannot responsibly say

Budget and council action uniformly increase compensation.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims CLAIM-G and CLAIM-H

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

Mixed and countervailing evidence

Mixed or countervailing

What I can responsibly say

Both safety and non-safety units use bargaining, steps, COLAs, and pay plans. The available evidence is consistent with a reinforcing safety-pressure bundle in some settings, but local and growth results are mixed and do not establish a uniform safety advantage.

Strict conclusion

Safety and non-safety units both use formal compensation-growth mechanisms; the comparative pattern in reviewed records is mixed.

Broader bounded conclusion

Both safety and non-safety units use bargaining, steps, COLAs, and pay plans. The available evidence is consistent with a reinforcing safety-pressure bundle in some settings, but local and growth results are mixed and do not establish a uniform safety advantage.

What I cannot responsibly say

Non-safety compensation lacks institutional growth mechanisms, or safety always has the advantage.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

A bounded compensation-mechanism account

Supported

What I can responsibly say

The reviewed corpus supports a bounded account of mechanisms and directional pressures affecting safety compensation more strongly than it supports any global wage-gap, prevalence, or causal-effect estimate.

Strict conclusion

The reviewed corpus supports a bounded account of mechanisms and directional pressures affecting safety compensation more strongly than it supports any global wage-gap, prevalence, or causal-effect estimate.

Broader bounded conclusion

The reviewed corpus supports a bounded account of mechanisms and directional pressures affecting safety compensation more strongly than it supports any global wage-gap, prevalence, or causal-effect estimate.

What I cannot responsibly say

The corpus estimates a national safety wage gap or causal effect.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims UNSUP-01 and UNSUP-02

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

No national safety wage-gap estimate

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

A national safety wage-gap estimate is not supported by the current corpus.

Strict conclusion

A national safety wage-gap estimate is not supported by the current corpus.

Broader bounded conclusion

A national safety wage-gap estimate is not supported by the current corpus.

What I cannot responsibly say

The corpus provides a national safety wage-gap estimate.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

No national mechanism-prevalence estimate

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

A national prevalence estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current corpus.

Strict conclusion

A national prevalence estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current corpus.

Broader bounded conclusion

A national prevalence estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current corpus.

What I cannot responsibly say

The corpus estimates national mechanism prevalence.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims UNSUP-03 and UNSUP-04

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

No causal-effect estimate

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

A causal effect estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current design.

Strict conclusion

A causal effect estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current design.

Broader bounded conclusion

A causal effect estimate for any compensation mechanism is not supported by the current design.

What I cannot responsibly say

The corpus identifies causal effects of compensation mechanisms.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

No regression-based claim

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

No regression-based claim is supported because no regression-ready design passed the gate and no regression was run.

Strict conclusion

No regression-based claim is supported because no regression-ready design passed the gate and no regression was run.

Broader bounded conclusion

No regression-based claim is supported because no regression-ready design passed the gate and no regression was run.

What I cannot responsibly say

Regression results establish the proposed relationship.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Claims UNSUP-05 and UNSUP-06

Compact adjudication cards preserve the exact class, defensible language, principal evidence, and prohibited wording.

No uniform safety growth advantage

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

A precise claim that safety wages grow a specified percentage faster is not supported by the available matched evidence.

Strict conclusion

A precise claim that safety wages grow a specified percentage faster is not supported by the available matched evidence.

Broader bounded conclusion

A precise claim that safety wages grow a specified percentage faster is not supported by the available matched evidence.

What I cannot responsibly say

Safety wages grow X percent faster nationally.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Documentation is not causal identification

Unsupported

What I can responsibly say

The evidence does not establish that a documented mechanism caused an observed wage difference.

Strict conclusion

The evidence does not establish that a documented mechanism caused an observed wage difference.

Broader bounded conclusion

The evidence does not establish that a documented mechanism caused an observed wage difference.

What I cannot responsibly say

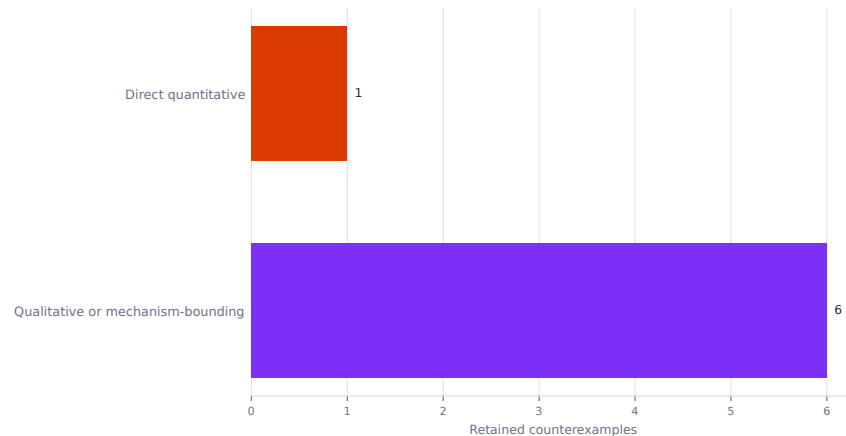
The documented mechanism caused the observed wage difference.

Main uncertainty

unsearched, storage-held, conflict, linkage, compatibility, and independent-human-review limits remain

Counterexamples and countervailing evidence

Seven retained records prevent the mechanism account from becoming a uniform safety-growth claim.



Seven counterexamples remain visible and bound the claims they affect.

Why they matter

One direct quantitative counterexample and six qualitative or mechanism-bounding records show that non-safety units also use bargaining, steps, COLAs, pay plans, and related mechanisms. They are part of the analysis, not decorative warnings.

1. Direct local comparison

Canastota's 2023-24 record lists Code Enforcement at \$24.82 per hour and a first-year police officer at \$23.91; role and tenure remain conditional.

3. National comparisons remain incompatible

Pay basis, period, and role comparability are incomplete across the national administrative material.

5. Local examples remain local

The reviewed local comparisons support bounded examples, not a scalable national wage-gap estimator.

7. Mechanisms are not causal effects

Documented institutional channels do not identify the counterfactual wage outcome required for a causal claim.

2. Fiscal formalization can cut both ways

Budget and adoption processes can delay, constrain, or reject compensation as well as authorize increases.

4. Document frequency is not prevalence

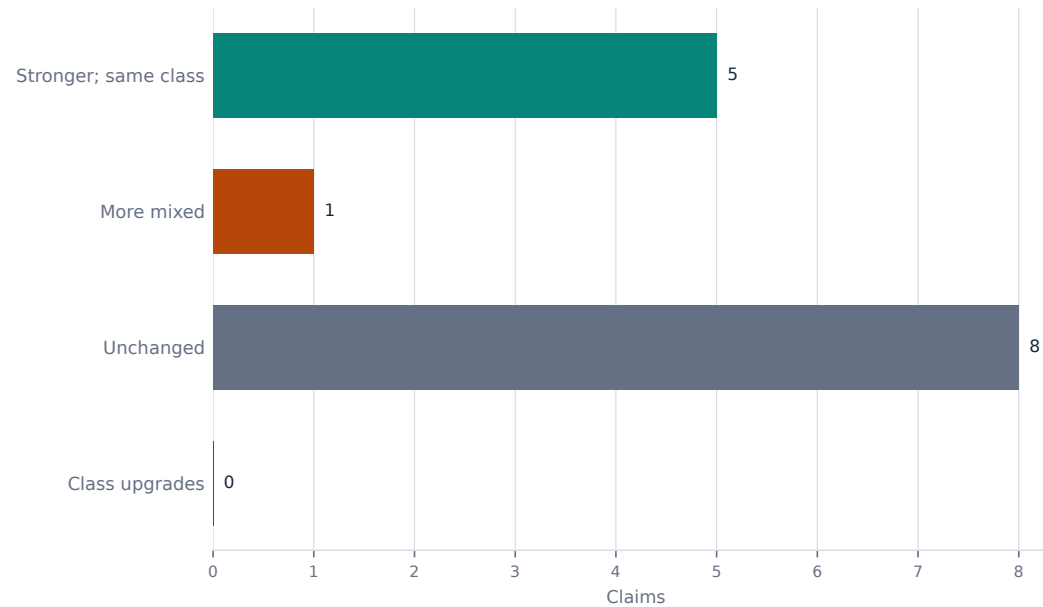
A compensation mechanism can be coded more than once within a source, so record counts cannot become population rates.

6. Non-safety mechanisms are visible

Non-safety units also receive bargaining, COLA, step, and pay-plan mechanisms, which bounds any safety-only account.

Strict evidence and broader evidence

Broader evidence strengthened interpretation without erasing the strict baseline or upgrading any claim class.



The broader evidence lanes increased usable evidence without erasing the strict baseline or upgrading any claim class.

Not established

No national safety wage-gap estimate

Not established

No national mechanism-prevalence estimate

Not established

No causal effect estimate

Not established

No regression-based claim

Not established

No uniform national safety-growth advantage

Not established

Documentation does not establish causation

Limitations 1: Research design and scope

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Research design and scope

Constraint

The corpus is not a representative national sample and has no national worker, bargaining-unit, or pay-record denominator.

What still worked

Scouting reached 35,574 of 35,589 eligible municipalities (99.9579%), and the retained corpus contains 15,163 unique PDFs with 1,029,482 native PDF pages.

Interpretation boundary

Near-complete discovery coverage is not analytical representativeness.

Discovery and hosted-search limits

Constraint

Of 18,689 intended residual targets, 12,844 remained unsearched after repeated source-less search outcomes. Those targets are unknown possibilities, not known missing evidence.

What still worked

Previously found candidates and verified sources remained intact, and the unsearched queue was preserved rather than treated as evidence of absence.

Interpretation boundary

The failure was consistent with a service or capacity limitation, but its exact cause was not exposed.

Limitations 2: Verification, access, and storage

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Verification, access, and storage

Constraint

Access blocks, unavailable URLs, corrupt payloads, and a 30 GiB retention ceiling left 7,895 verified sources storage-held and 24,569 low-value context sources deferred.

What still worked

The project retained 14,449 unique external payloads with hashes and source pointers and kept storage holds separate from substantive rejections.

Interpretation boundary

Storage-held sources were not processed for this revision.

Document readiness

Constraint

PDFs, HTML, tables, CSVs, embedded data, shells, and low-text files required different paths; 118 sources were deferred for OCR and 97 needed extraction repair.

What still worked

Of 14,703 inspected retained-source records, 14,257 were extraction-ready and 14,160 produced usable payloads.

Interpretation boundary

OCR deferral means image-only documents were not silently treated as empty.

Limitations 3: Extraction volume and compaction

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Extraction volume and compaction

Constraint

Extraction produced 5,558,770 raw field hits and 4,289,437 raw spans. Repeated tables, boilerplate, and ambiguous labels meant those were not independent facts.

What still worked

Deterministic compaction reduced the field layer by 66.25% and preserved 1,876,183 compact administrative observations.

Interpretation boundary

Large row counts measure processing volume, not evidence prevalence.

Analytical framing and table calibration

Constraint

Early wage-table signals were not reliable enough to become a clean comparable wage panel; a five-case rendered challenge contradicted all five assisted outcomes.

What still worked

The project did not force those signals into estimates. It expanded to staffing, implementation, documentary growth, local comparisons, and compensation mechanisms.

Interpretation boundary

The broader framing improved evidence use but did not manufacture missing wage matches.

Limitations 4: Rating and semantic review

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Rating and semantic review

Constraint

The new external administrative layer did not receive GABRIEL scoring. Deterministic rules and bounded semantic AI review are not independent human gold coding.

What still worked

Claim-critical review examined 1,726 unique records; 368 sampled second-pass QA records passed, and 201 conflicts remained unresolved rather than conveniently resolved.

Interpretation boundary

Earlier eligible documentary evidence did use GABRIEL where available.

Reconciliation and comparability

Constraint

Side, period, role, pay basis, and compensation basis often did not align: 1,523,558 observations remained side-unresolved, with 131,124 basis holds and 266,849 conflict-sensitive observations.

What still worked

The project preserved 18,358 staffing units, 1,268 implementation sequences, 10 bounded local comparisons, and 432 documentary growth records.

Interpretation boundary

The external layer still produced zero compatible wage matches, growth pairs, vacancy rates, overtime shares, or total-compensation sums.

Limitations 5: Safety and non-safety evidence imbalance

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Safety and non-safety evidence imbalance

Constraint

Safety-specific records are more visible, while non-safety pay is often embedded in broad budgets or personnel schedules and many records remain unresolved.

What still worked

The analysis keeps safety, non-safety, mixed, side-independent, and unresolved records separate and reports exact denominators.

Interpretation boundary

Documentation absence cannot be treated as real-world absence or national prevalence.

Mathematical and causal design

Constraint

Only 3 of 16 regression-readiness gates passed. There was no defensible external matched wage panel or causal identification design.

What still worked

No regression was run and no national wage-gap, prevalence, or causal estimate was produced; strict descriptive and mechanism findings were retained.

Interpretation boundary

Not running an invalid model is a substantive quality decision.

Limitations 6: Locality and visual grouping

Each constraint is paired with what the project still accomplished and the boundary it imposes.

Locality and visual grouping

Constraint

Local comparisons remain local; maps show documented events, not workers, wage-effect size, or prevalence; grouping compresses source lineage.

What still worked

All 14 claims were adjudicated, seven counterexamples remained visible, and 201 high-impact conflicts stayed outside clean totals.

Interpretation boundary

Appendix tables preserve the category and claim lineage hidden by concise profiles.

Operational and infrastructure limits

Constraint

Hosted search failed, storage filled, checkpoint designs scaled poorly, some parsers hung, interfaces interrupted coordination, and deployment jobs were delayed.

What still worked

Lane-owned files, append-only ledgers, checkpoints, quarantine, hashes, and resume-only logic preserved accepted work. Phase 0 inventoried about 119.88 GiB without deleting it.

Interpretation boundary

Operational recovery protected evidence but added monitoring and reconciliation cost.

What worked, what did not, and what remains possible

The limits narrow the claims; they do not erase the project's traceable evidence and reusable infrastructure.

What worked

- 99.9579% municipality scout coverage
- More than one million native PDF pages
- 14,160 usable external payloads
- 1,876,183 compact observations
- Staffing, implementation, local, growth, and mechanism evidence

What did not become possible

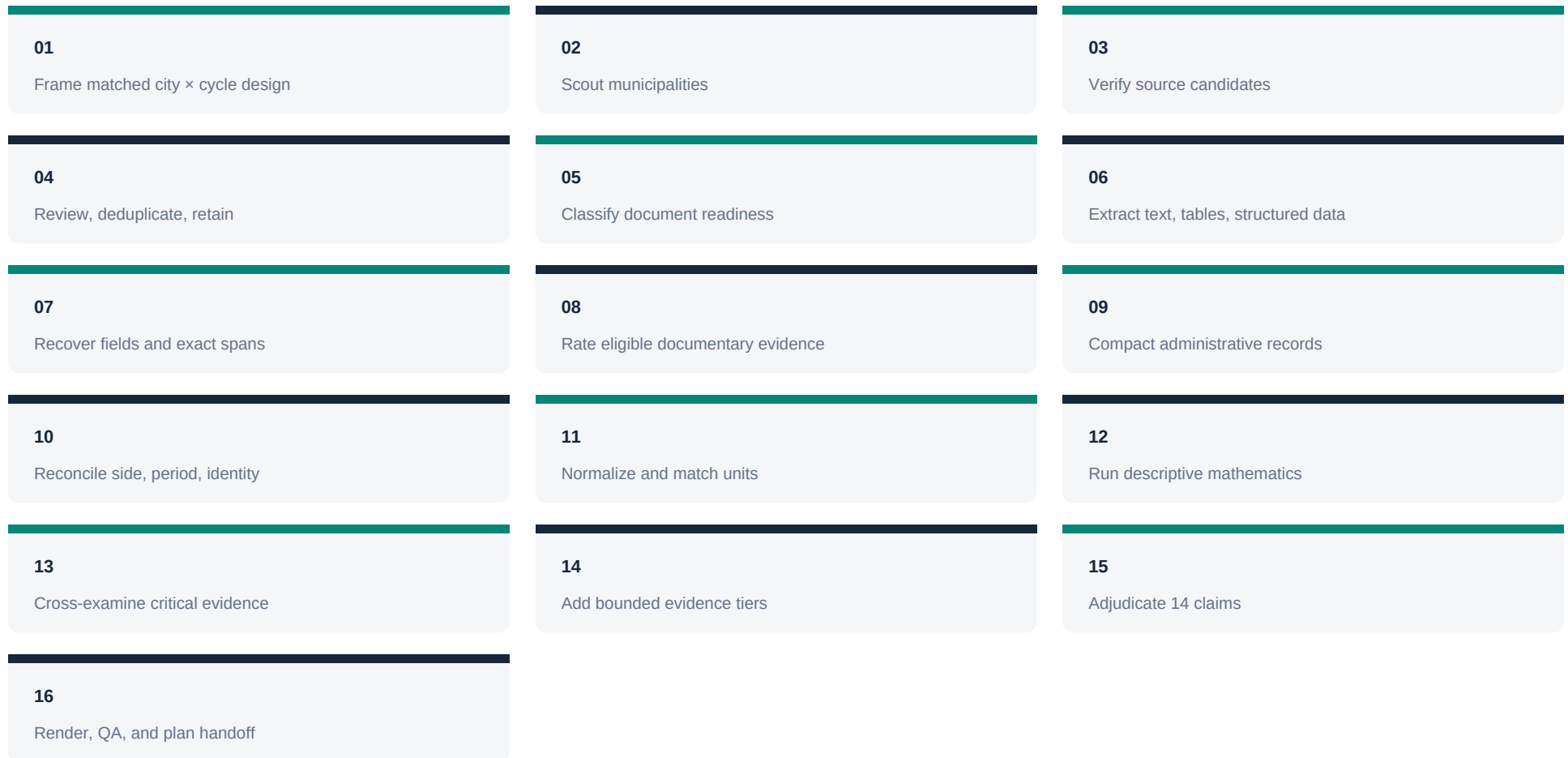
- Representative national sampling
- Compatible external wage or growth panel
- National prevalence estimate
- Regression or causal effect
- Uniform safety growth advantage

What remains possible

- Targeted source recovery
- Better matched local panels
- Human review of selected conflicts
- Improved side and pay-basis classification
- Future longitudinal and causal designs

Full project workflow

I directed the research question, evidence standards, analytical priorities, and final judgment. The workflow moved from discovery through claim adjudication without treating raw extraction volume as proof.



I directed the research question, evidence standards, analytical priorities, and final judgment. The workflow moved from discovery through claim adjudication without treating raw extraction volume as proof.

From a continuing log to relay packages

The project began with a continuing PROGRESS.md record. Relay ZIPs later carried commits, validation, decisions, blockers, uncertainties, and the next bounded task between ChatGPT and Codex.

01

PROGRESS.md recorded decisions and next steps

02

Self-contained prompts locked each stage

03

Lane outputs preserved partial progress

04

Relay ZIPs recorded commits, validation, blockers, and next task

05

ChatGPT read relays and designed the next bounded prompt

The project began with a continuing PROGRESS.md record. Relay ZIPs later carried commits, validation, decisions, blockers, uncertainties, and the next bounded task between ChatGPT and Codex.

Human and AI roles; tools by stage

Human direction, AI orchestration, local execution, and documentary scoring had distinct roles. The later external administrative layer used deterministic local processing and bounded semantic AI review.

01

Joachim — question, priorities, corrections, standards, voice,

02

ChatGPT — orchestration prompts, analytical frameworks,

03

Codex — local scripts, files, lane runs, checkpoints,

04

GABRIEL — ratings for eligible earlier documentary

05

Deterministic local rules — later administrative processing

06

Scouting — structured hosted search

07

Verification — HTTP and locator checks

08

Retention — downloads, hashing, exact-payload

09

Readiness — text-layer and table checks; OCR deferral

10

Extraction — PDF/HTML/table/embedded-data parsing

11

Rating — GABRIEL on eligible documentary material

12

Compaction — deterministic reduction of noisy hits

13

Reconciliation — municipality, side, period, identity, source

14

Analysis — compatibility, formulas, descriptive math

15

Cross-examination — exact excerpts, rows, context,

16

Visuals — local plotting, geospatial rendering, PDF page QA

Human direction, AI orchestration, local execution, and documentary scoring had distinct roles. The later external administrative layer used deterministic local processing and bounded semantic AI review.

Codex execution, worktrees, and staggered lanes

Large tasks were divided into disjoint portions with lane-owned files, staggered starts, frequent checkpoints, resume-only-incomplete logic, and a coordinator merge. Worktrees were useful in some pilots but added coordination and merge burden.

01

Small pilots established schemas and failure modes

02

Early parallel pilots used isolated Git worktrees

03

Later stages used locked lane inputs and lane-owned

04

Heavy profile guided architecture and difficult pipeline stages

05

Routine guidance covered deterministic rebuilds and

06

Coordinator merges protected shared summaries

07

Split a large task into disjoint rows, states, sources, claims,

08

Lock each lane's input and hash

09

Start workers several minutes apart

10

Write only lane-owned files

11

Checkpoint accepted work frequently

12

Resume incomplete work only

13

Merge after all lanes finish

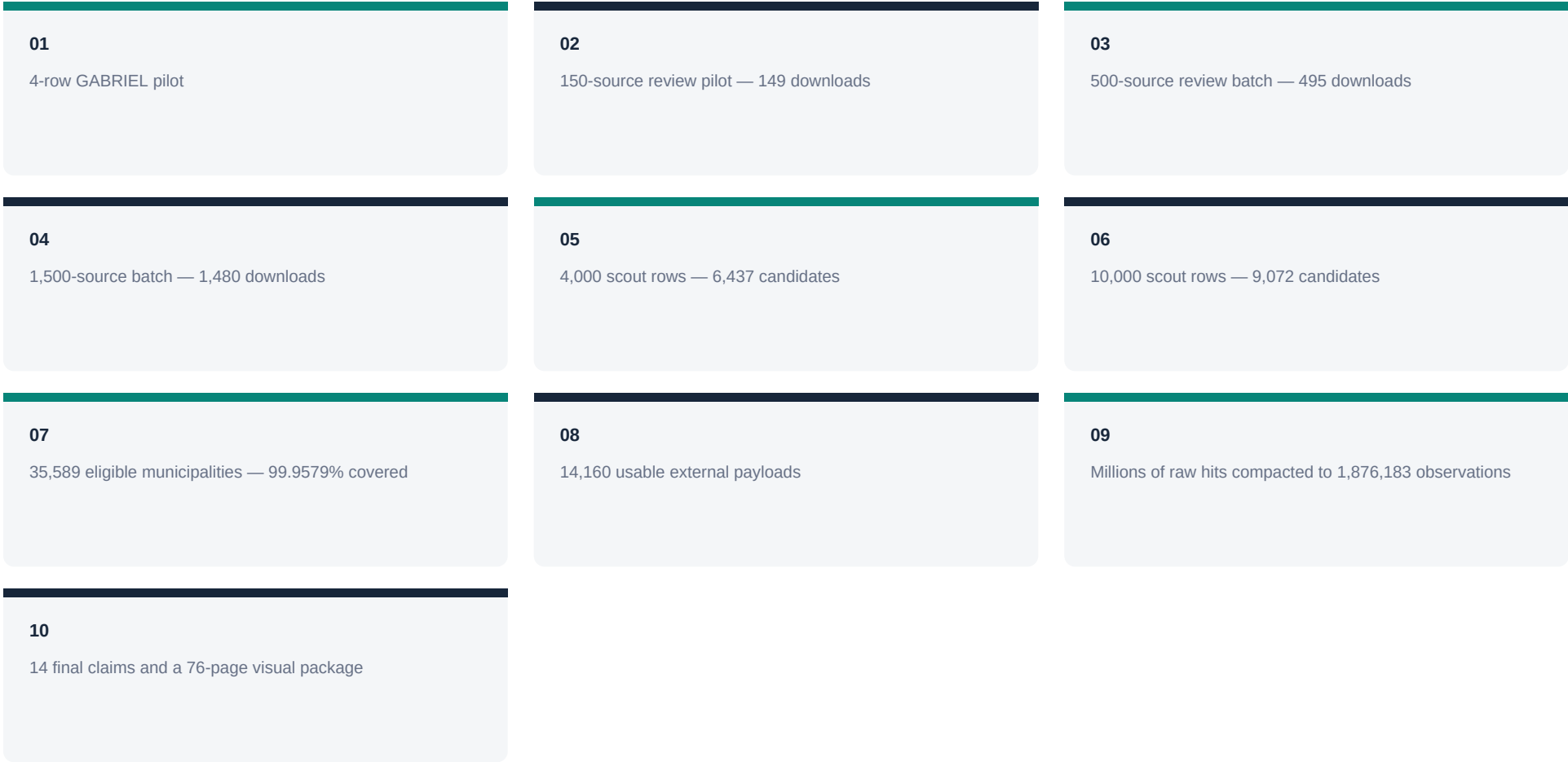
14

Audit shared counts and lineage

Large tasks were divided into disjoint portions with lane-owned files, staggered starts, frequent checkpoints, resume-only-incomplete logic, and a coordinator merge. Worktrees were useful in some pilots but added coordination and merge burden.

Representative scaling milestones

The workflow scaled from small pilots to thousands of municipalities and millions of extracted records. Representative milestones show the change without turning the atlas into a task log.



The workflow scaled from small pilots to thousands of municipalities and millions of extracted records. Representative milestones show the change without turning the atlas into a task log.

Failures and repairs: evidence pipeline

The workflow was not linear. Search, storage, checkpoint, and parser failures were diagnosed while preserving accepted work and source lineage.

01

Dirty worktree — classified active rendered assets instead of deleting them

02

Source-less hosted search — stopped production and preserved 12,844 targets

03

Large checkpoints — replaced arrays with append-only ledgers

04

30 GiB ceiling — retained 14,449 payloads and held 7,895

05

Parser timeouts — added child-process wall limits

The workflow was not linear. Search, storage, checkpoint, and parser failures were diagnosed while preserving accepted work and source lineage.

Failures and repairs: analysis and publication

Later failures affected lookup performance, coordination, strict matching, deployment, and inventory scale. Repairs remained bounded to affected outputs.

01

Quadratic lookup — indexed and resumed incomplete inputs only

02

Interface interruption — accepted 14,160 payloads remained valid

03

Strict matching — kept zero-match baseline and added bounded tiers

04

Deployment delay — verified direct URL and committed checksum

05

Phase 0 launcher/output issues — repaired only task-owned inventory files

Later failures affected lookup performance, coordination, strict matching, deployment, and inventory scale. Repairs remained bounded to affected outputs.

Evidence tiers remained separate

I kept the strict result and added broader bounded and directional layers. Five claims strengthened within class, one became more mixed, eight were unchanged, and none upgraded class.

01

Strict evidence — exact and claim-safe

02

Bounded evidence — compatible with an explicit caveat

03

Directional evidence — mechanism or direction, no precise magnitude

04

Context — relevant but not claim support

05

Rejected — incompatible, duplicate, conflicted, or unsupported

06

Result — five claims strengthened in class; one became more mixed; eight unchanged; zero upgrades

I kept the strict result and added broader bounded and directional layers. Five claims strengthened within class, one became more mixed, eight were unchanged, and none upgraded class.

Reader-facing categories 1–4

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Payroll Effective Date

1,876 distinct implementation events · 1,119 municipalities · 42 states

Safety 786

Non-safety 105

Alaska 3

The date on which an approved compensation change becomes operative in payroll.

It determines when an approved increase starts reaching paychecks and prevents adoption dates from being mistaken for payment.

Retroactive

1,418 distinct implementation events · 922 municipalities · 42 states

Safety 597

Non-safety 52

Alaska 6

A compensation term whose effective date reaches back before the final approval or payment date.

It can push compensation upward by making a later settlement effective for earlier work.

Retroactive Pay

1,418 distinct implementation events · 922 municipalities · 42 states

Safety 597

Non-safety 52

Alaska 6

Back pay owed because an agreement or award applies to an earlier period.

It converts the earlier effective period into an owed payment, often delivered as back pay.

Recurring

720 distinct implementation events · 515 municipalities · 35 states

Safety 337

Non-safety 27

Alaska 5

A compensation component that continues in the regular schedule instead of ending after one payment.

It raises future compensation repeatedly because the amount remains in the pay structure.

Reader-facing categories 5–8

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Fiscal Constraint

619 distinct implementation events · 395 municipalities · 33 states

Safety 152

Non-safety 69

Alaska 1

Budget pressure or limited fiscal capacity that narrows the compensation choices available to a municipality.

It can hold pay down, delay implementation, or redirect increases toward narrower groups or one-time payments.

Budget Pay Plan Process

617 distinct implementation events · 391 municipalities · 31 states

Safety 146

Non-safety 68

Alaska 1

A budget or pay-plan process that formally sets or revises compensation schedules.

It can authorize, sequence, or constrain the schedules through which wages become operative.

Across The Board Raise

373 distinct implementation events · 298 municipalities · 34 states

Safety 178

Non-safety 11

Alaska 3

The same general increase applied across covered jobs or classifications.

It raises covered rates together, but does not necessarily change the gap between safety and non-safety jobs.

One Time

299 distinct implementation events · 242 municipalities · 25 states

Safety 139

Non-safety 10

Alaska 2

A payment or adjustment that does not recur in the regular base schedule.

It raises current compensation without permanently increasing the base schedule.

Reader-facing categories 9–12

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Non Base Compensation Other

292 distinct implementation events · 195 municipalities · 18 states

Safety 174

Non-safety 12

Alaska 0

Compensation outside regular base wages that does not fit a more specific category.

It adds pay outside the base rate, so a base-wage comparison can miss part of compensation.

Ordinance Council Adoption

255 distinct implementation events · 221 municipalities · 33 states

Safety 61

Non-safety 17

Alaska 3

A city council or ordinance action that formally authorizes compensation terms.

It turns a proposal or agreement into an authorized municipal action, although authorization is not proof of payment.

Ordinance Adoption

206 distinct implementation events · 188 municipalities · 35 states

Safety 50

Non-safety 12

Alaska 2

Formal adoption of compensation terms through an ordinance.

It formalizes compensation terms, but the retained evidence must still show implementation or payment separately.

Base Wage Change

120 distinct implementation events · 98 municipalities · 19 states

Safety 59

Non-safety 3

Alaska 0

A change to the recurring base wage or salary rate.

It directly changes recurring salary or wage rates.

Reader-facing categories 13–16

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Step Progression

87 distinct implementation events · 74 municipalities · 18 states

Safety 45

Non-safety 7

Alaska 1

Movement through a salary schedule based on service, rank, or another progression rule.

It can generate repeated wage growth as employees move through scheduled steps.

COLA CPI Adjustment

79 distinct implementation events · 61 municipalities · 23 states

Safety 35

Non-safety 5

Alaska 0

A cost-of-living adjustment, sometimes linked to inflation or a price index.

It can preserve purchasing power by linking raises to inflation or a stated percentage.

Uniform Or Equipment Allowance

68 distinct implementation events · 56 municipalities · 13 states

Safety 36

Non-safety 4

Alaska 0

A payment for required uniforms, equipment, maintenance, or related costs.

It increases cash compensation or reimburses required job costs without changing base pay.

Benefit Cost Change

65 distinct implementation events · 53 municipalities · 15 states

Safety 28

Non-safety 5

Alaska 0

A change in benefit value, employee contributions, or employer benefit costs.

It can change total compensation or take-home value even when base wages do not move.

Reader-facing categories 17–20

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Budget Appropriation

64 distinct implementation events · 58 municipalities · 24 states

Safety 17

Non-safety 6

Alaska 0

A budget allocation that authorizes or funds compensation.

It supplies the legal or financial authority for compensation to be paid.

Stipend Or Premium

62 distinct implementation events · 52 municipalities · 15 states

Safety 30

Non-safety 1

Alaska 1

Supplemental pay for assignments, qualifications, shifts, or special duties.

It raises pay for specific duties, qualifications, shifts, or working conditions.

Settlement Or MOU

58 distinct implementation events · 48 municipalities · 19 states

Safety 27

Non-safety 4

Alaska 0

A settlement or memorandum of understanding that changes compensation terms.

It can implement targeted changes faster or more narrowly than a complete successor contract.

Market Recruitment Retention

44 distinct implementation events · 35 municipalities · 16 states

Safety 17

Non-safety 5

Alaska 0

A pay action justified by labor-market competition, hiring, or retention pressure.

It can produce targeted raises or premiums when employers struggle to hire or keep workers.

Reader-facing categories 21–24

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Classification Band Change

43 distinct implementation events · 40 municipalities · 13 states

Safety 19

Non-safety 2

Alaska 0

A change to a job classification, pay grade, range, or band.

It can raise or lower attainable pay by moving a job into a different grade or range.

Longevity

40 distinct implementation events · 35 municipalities · 13 states

Safety 18

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

Additional compensation tied to years of service.

It adds scheduled pay as service accumulates and can steepen wage growth for long-tenured workers.

Overtime

38 distinct implementation events · 36 municipalities · 15 states

Safety 15

Non-safety 2

Alaska 0

Compensation for hours or duties beyond the regular schedule.

It can substantially increase earnings beyond base pay when staffing or scheduling produces extra hours.

Inflation Indexing

31 distinct implementation events · 22 municipalities · 8 states

Safety 21

Non-safety 0

Alaska 0

A compensation rule explicitly linked to inflation or a price index.

It can trigger recurring adjustments as inflation changes.

Reader-facing categories 25–28

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Holiday Pay

22 distinct implementation events · 19 municipalities · 9 states

Safety 13

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

Premium or additional compensation for holidays.

It adds premium compensation for holiday work or recognized holidays.

Lump Sum

18 distinct implementation events · 16 municipalities · 6 states

Safety 14

Non-safety 0

Alaska 0

A single payment rather than a recurring wage-rate increase.

It increases compensation once but does not by itself raise future base wages.

Bargaining Leverage

17 distinct implementation events · 15 municipalities · 6 states

Safety 12

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

The practical power employees or unions can use to win better terms during negotiations.

It can improve negotiated terms when employees can credibly apply staffing, political, legal, or job-action pressure.

Collective Bargaining

17 distinct implementation events · 15 municipalities · 6 states

Safety 12

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

Negotiation between a public employer and represented employees over compensation.

It provides the formal channel through which wage schedules and non-base terms are negotiated.

Reader-facing categories 29–32

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Salary Range Change

12 distinct implementation events · 12 municipalities · 5 states

Safety 2

Non-safety 0

Alaska 0

A change to the minimum, maximum, or span of a salary range.

It changes the floor, ceiling, or spread of possible pay rather than necessarily changing observed earnings immediately.

Contract Ratification

9 distinct implementation events · 9 municipalities · 6 states

Safety 5

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

Formal approval of negotiated contract terms by the relevant parties.

It approves negotiated terms but remains distinct from their payroll-effective or paid stage.

Vacancy Pressure

8 distinct implementation events · 8 municipalities · 4 states

Safety 2

Non-safety 2

Alaska 0

Unfilled jobs or vacancy conditions cited in compensation or staffing decisions.

It can motivate targeted raises, premiums, or retention measures when positions are hard to fill.

Reimbursement

7 distinct implementation events · 6 municipalities · 4 states

Safety 2

Non-safety 1

Alaska 0

Repayment of eligible work-related expenses rather than ordinary wages.

It offsets work expenses but should not be treated as recurring wages.

Reader-facing categories 33–35

Category counts and Alaska status are preserved beneath the integrated profiles.

Comparability Parity

6 distinct implementation events · 6 municipalities · 5 states

Safety 4 **Non-safety 0** **Alaska 0**

Compensation linked to comparison with another role, unit, or jurisdiction.

It can pull pay toward a reference job, bargaining unit, or neighboring jurisdiction.

Classification Civil Service

4 distinct implementation events · 4 municipalities · 2 states

Safety 2 **Non-safety 0** **Alaska 0**

Civil-service or classification rules that structure pay placement or progression.

It governs placement and progression in ways that can structure long-run pay paths.

Interest Arbitration

1 distinct implementation event · 1 municipality · 1 state

Safety 1 **Non-safety 0** **Alaska 0**

A neutral decision process that resolves a bargaining impasse over contract terms.

It can impose compensation terms when ordinary bargaining reaches an impasse.

Unclassified or no direct compensation outcome

These categories describe evidence status, not reader-facing wage-setting processes.

None Identified

The retained record documents compensation activity but does not identify a specific wage-setting process. Count: 2,001 distinct implementation events. Safety 890; non-safety 71; other or unresolved 1,040. This category remains outside the compensation-mechanism profiles.

No Direct Compensation Outcome

An administrative event for which the retained record does not show a direct pay outcome. Count: 544 distinct implementation events. Safety 142; non-safety 60; other or unresolved 342. This category remains outside the compensation-mechanism profiles.

Unclear

The record points to a compensation event but does not identify the mechanism clearly. Count: 140 distinct implementation events. Safety 55; non-safety 12; other or unresolved 73. This category remains outside the compensation-mechanism profiles.

Technical counts and analytical boundaries

Counts with different units remain separate.

Corpus

15,163 unique PDFs · 1,029,482 native PDF pages · 8,718 substantive HTML documents · 96,484 HTML tables · 1,017,511 table rows · 132,188 structured records · 1,445 CSV/TSV rows.

Source inventory

26,799 physical source candidates · 26,637 unique sources after exact duplicate grouping · 14,449 retained external payloads · 14,160 usable extracted payloads.

Discovery and storage

12,844 residual targets remain unsearched · 7,895 verified sources remain storage-held. Neither count reveals the direction of missing evidence.

Mechanism layer

2,998 root implementation events · 13,391 mechanism records before event-level grouping · 13,526 linked administrative sources · 1,314 linked municipalities. Record counts are not prevalence.

Claims

14 final claims · 7 counterexamples · 201 unresolved high-impact conflicts · 0 national wage-gap estimates · 0 regressions · 0 causal estimates.

Page-equivalent boundary

The separate 650,482 non-PDF text-page equivalent is reported independently and is never added to native PDF pages.

Source and method notes

The atlas is a reader-facing summary; project documentation preserves exact lineage and reconstruction instructions.

Source lineage

Every claim-supporting layer retains source pointers, coordinates, registry hashes, and source-level review outcomes in the project repository. This atlas does not reproduce the full evidence corpus.

Human and AI methodology

I set the research question, priorities, evidence standards, framing, and final judgment. ChatGPT designed staged orchestration and QA. Codex executed local workflows. GABRIEL rated eligible earlier documentary evidence; later administrative evidence used deterministic local processing and bounded semantic AI review.

Review boundary

Bounded semantic AI review is not independent human gold coding. Unresolved conflicts remain unresolved, rejected evidence remains excluded, and claim classes do not change in this publication stage.

Scope of this atlas

This document summarizes mechanisms, final claim boundaries, counterexamples, limitations, and methodology. It does not reproduce original source files or the full extracted and structured evidence layers.